

Epinomis

ΕΠΙΝΟΜΙΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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CL: Well, stranger, here we are, duly assembled, all three of us as we agreed, you and me and Megillus here, to consider what account we should give of the sort of understanding which, according to us, once apprehended, gives a person the finest understanding a human being can possibly have. For although we maintain that we have, in general, described all matters concerned with lawgiving, we have neither investigated nor referred to the most important question: what exactly should a mere mortal learn in order to become wise? So we should now attempt to make good this omission. Indeed, we run the risk of failing to complete the objective of all our endeavours, which was to clarify everything from beginning to end.

ΚΛ. πρὸς μὲν τὸ τῆς ὁμολογίας ἤκομεν ἅπαντες ὀρθῶς, ὦ ξένε, τρεῖς ὄντες, ἐγὼ καὶ σὺ καὶ Μέγιλλος ὅδε, τὸ τῆς φρονήσεως ἐπισκεψόμενοι τίνι ποτὲ χρὴ λόγῳ διεξελεῖν, ὃ τὴν ἀνθρωπίνην ἔξιν φαμέν, ὅταν διανοηθῇ, κάλλιστ' ἔχειν ποιεῖν πρὸς φρόνησιν ὅσην δυνατόν ἀνθρώπῳ σχεῖν. τὰ μὲν

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AT: Well said, Clinias. I believe the argument you're about to hear is unusual, and also, in a sense, not so strange at all. Indeed, many people, based upon their experience of life, proffer the same argument – that humankind will never be blessed or happy. Follow me, then, and decide whether or not you think I am right in what I say, along with them, about such a matter. I deny the possibility of humanity, with few exceptions, being blessed and happy, at least during this lifetime. But on dying, there is a noble hope of encountering everything that we are so eager for, as we live the very best life we can whilst alive, and we aim for the noblest departure when we die. I am not saying anything wise, but something that all Greeks and non-Greeks would somehow recognise: that from the very outset, being born is a difficulty for every creature. First, there is involvement in the condition of all who dwell in the womb, then there is the actual birth, followed by nurture and education, and everyone agrees that all of these give rise to a great

deal of trouble. And, indeed, if we don't count the travails but only what people would regard as acceptable, the duration would be quite short, providing a sort of breathing space, it seems, in the middle phase of human life. But old age sets in quickly, making anyone who is not full of naïve notions reluctant to live life all over again, having reflected upon the life that has just been lived.

γὰρ ἄλλα, ὥς φαμεν, ἅπαντα διεξήλθομεν ὅσα ἦν περὶ νόμων θέσιν· ὁ δὲ μέγιστον εὐρεῖν τε καὶ εἰπεῖν, τί ποτε μαθὼν θνητὸς ἄνθρωπος σοφὸς ἂν εἴη, τοῦτο οὔτε εἶπομεν οὔτε ἠΰρομεν, νῦν τε πειρώμεθα τοῦτο μὴ καταλιπεῖν· σχεδὸν γὰρ ἀτελὲς ἂν πράξαιμεν οὐ χάριν ἅπαντες ὠρμήσαμεν, ὥς φανερά ποιήσοντες ἐξ ἀρχῆς μέχρι τέλους. ΑΘ. ὦ φίλε Κλεινία, καλῶς μὲν λέγεις, ἄτοπον μὴν ἀκούσεσθαι σε λόγον οἶμαι, καὶ τινα τρόπον οὐκ ἄτοπον αὖ. πολλοὶ γὰρ δὴ προστυχεῖς τῷ βίῳ γιγνόμενοι τὸν αὐτὸν λόγον φέρουσιν, ὥς οὐκ ἔσται μακάριον τὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων γένος οὐδ' εὐδαιμον. ἔπου δὴ καὶ σύνιδε ἂν σοι δοκῶ καγὼ μετ' αὐτῶν καλῶς τοῦ τοιούτου πέρι λέγειν. οὐ φημι εἶναι δυνατόν ἀνθρώποις μακαρίοις τε καὶ εὐδαιμόσις γενέσθαι πλὴν ὀλίγων—μέχριπερ ἂν ζῶμεν τοῦτο διορίζομαι· καλὴ δὲ ἐλπίς τελευτήσαντι τυχεῖν ἀπάντων ὧν ἔνεκά τις προθυμοῖτ' ἂν ζῶν τε ὥς κάλλιστ' ἂν ζῆν κατὰ δύναμιν καὶ τελευτήσας τελευτῆς τοιαύτης τυχεῖν—λέγω δ' οὐδὲν σοφόν, ἀλλ' ὅπερ ἅπαντες Ἕλληνές τε καὶ βάρβαροι γινώσκομέν τινα τρόπον, ὥς ἐξ ἀρχῆς τὸ γενέσθαι χαλεπὸν ἅπαντι ζῶν· πρῶτον μὲν τὸ μετασχεῖν τῆς τῶν κυουμένων ἕξεως, ἔπειτ' αὖ τὸ γίγνεσθαι, καὶ ἔτι τὸ τρέφεσθαι καὶ παιδεύεσθαι, διὰ πόνων μυρίων ταῦτα γίγνεσθαι σύμπαντα, ὥς φαμεν ἅπαντες. ΑΘ. καὶ χρόνος βραχυὲς ἂν τις εἴη πρὸς λογισμὸν μὴ τοι τῶν μοχθηρῶν, ἀλλ' ὁ πᾶς ἂν ὑπολάβοι μέτριον. οὗτος δὲ σχεδὸν ἀναπνοὴν δοκεῖ ποιεῖν τινα κατὰ μέσον πη βίον τὸν ἀνθρώπινον· ταχὺ γε μὴν ἐπιλάβον γῆρας ὄντιν οὖν ποιήσει' ἂν μήποτ' ἐθελῆσαι πάλιν ἀναβῶναι, λογισάμενον τὸν βεβιωμένον ἑαυτῷ βίον, ὅστις μὴ τυγχάνει παιδικῆς δόξης μεστὸς ὢν. τούτων δὴ τί ποτέ μοι τεκμήριον; ὅτι πέφυκεν ταύτῃ τὸ νῦν ζητούμενον

AT: So, what evidence do I have for all this? This is the nature of the subject of our current investigation. We are investigating the manner in which we may become wise on the assumption that each of us has this capacity in some measure. But it takes flight and is gone once someone embarks upon any understanding of the so-called skills or the other areas of understanding or branches of knowledge, as none of these deserves the title of wisdom concerning these human affairs. But our soul is strongly convinced and intuits that it somehow possesses this wisdom by nature, although it is quite unable to find out when and how, or even to discover what it is. Now, doesn't the problem with our enquiry into wisdom bear a strong resemblance to this? Shall we agree that this is how matters stand, or not?

τῷ λόγῳ. ζητοῦμεν δὲ διὰ τίνα τρόπον σοφοὶ γενησόμεθα, ὥς οὔσης τινὸς ἐκάστοις ταύτης τῆς δυνάμεως· ἡ δὲ φυγὴ φεύγει τότε ὅταν τις πρὸς τίνα φρόνησιν ἢ τῶν λεγομένων τεχνῶν ἢ φρονήσεων ἢ τινῶν ἄλλων τοιούτων ὥς οἴομεθα ἐπιστημῶν, ὥς ἀξίας τούτων οὐδεμιᾶς οὔσης ἐπὶ κλησὶν ῥηθῆναι τῆς περὶ ταῦτα σοφίας ἀνθρώπινα, τῆς δὲ ψυχῆς σφόδρα πεποιθυίας καὶ μαντευομένης ὥς οὔσης αὐτῇ κατὰ

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CL: We shall agree, stranger, based perhaps on the hope that, in your company, in due course, the truest possible opinion on these matters may eventually arise.

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AT: Well, we must first review the other kinds of knowledge, so-called, whose acquisition does not render the possessor wise. Well, in the first place, of those which constitute the primary needs of the mortal race we should note that, although these branches of knowledge are more or less the most necessary of all, their possessor is certainly not regarded as wise nowadays. And since it is not by our skill, it seems, but by nature subject to God that we have all come to manage the earth, agriculture will never really make us wise either. Nor indeed will the building of houses, or construction in general, the manufacture of various sorts of equipment, the work of the blacksmith, the carpenter,

the potter, the weaver, and the provision of all sorts of tools. This knowledge is of benefit to the populace, but it is not said to confer excellence. Nor again does hunting in all its forms ever elevate the soul and confer wisdom; neither does prophecy or its interpretation do so at all, for the prophet merely knows what he is saying without understanding whether it is true or not.

τινα φύσιν ταύτης, τίς δέ ἐστιν καὶ πότε καὶ πῶς, οὐ πάνυ δυναμένης ἐξευρίσκειν. ἄρ' οὐ τούτῳ σφόδρα προσείχ' ἡμῶν ἡ περὶ σοφίαν ἀπορία καὶ ζήτησις, πλείων τῆς ἐλπίδος ἐκάστω γιγνομένη τῶν ὅσοι ἐν ἡμῖν δυνατοὶ γίνονται φρονίμως αὐτοὺς ἄλλους τε ἐξετάσαι συμφώνως διὰ λόγων πάντων καὶ πάντῃ λεγομένων; ταῦτα οὐχ οὕτως ἢ ταύτῃ συμφήσομεν ἔχειν; ΚΛ. συμφήσομεν ἐπ' ἐλπίδι σοι ἴσως ταῦτ', ὦ ξένε, τῇ μετὰ σοῦ κατὰ χρόνον ἂν γενομένη, δοξάσαι περὶ αὐτῶν εἰς αὐθις τὸ ἀληθέστατον. ΑΘ. τὰς ἄλλας τοίνυν ὅσαι ἐπιστῆμαι μὲν εἰσιν λεγόμεναι, σοφὸν δὲ οὐκ ἀποτελοῦσιν τὸν λαμβάνοντά τε αὐτάς καὶ ἔχοντα, πρῶτον διεξιτέον, ὅπως ταύτας ἐκποδῶν θέμενοι, πειρώμεθα ἐκείνας ὧν δεόμεθα παραθέσθαι τε καὶ παραθέμενοι μανθάνειν. πρῶτον μὲν τοίνυν ὧν πρῶτον δεῖ θνητῷ γένει, ἴδωμεν ὡς εἰσὶ μὲν ἀναγκαιόταται σχεδὸν ἀληθῶς τε πρῶται, ὃ δὲ ἐπιστήμων αὐτῶν γιγνόμενος, εἰ καὶ κατ' ἀρχὰς ἔδοξέν τις εἶναι ποτε σοφός, οὐκουν νῦν γε οὔτε σοφὸς εἶναι δοξάζεται ὀνειδίη τε ἴσχει μᾶλλον ἀπὸ τῆς τοιαύτης ἐπιστήμης. ΑΘ. ἐροῦμεν δὴ αἴ τ' εἰσὶν καὶ ὅτι πᾶς ἀνὴρ αὐτάς, σχεδὸν ὅσοις ἀγὼν πρόκειται τοῦ δοκεῖν ὡς ἄριστον ἄνδρα συμβῆναι γενόμενον ἂν, φεύγει διὰ τὰς κτήσεις τῆς φρονήσεως τε καὶ ἐπιτηδεύσεως. ἔστω δὴ πρῶτον μὲν ἡ τῆς ἀλληλοφαγίας τῶν ζώων ἡμᾶς τῶν μὲν, ὡς ὁ μῦθος ἐστιν, τὸ παράπαν ἀποστήσασα, τῶν δὲ εἰς τὴν νόμιμον ἐδωδὴν καταστήσασα. ἴλεω δ' ἡμῖν οἱ πρόσθεν εἴησάν τε καὶ εἰσὶν—οὔτινες μὲν

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AT: Now, we can see that the acquisition of our necessities is achieved by means of skill, but that none of the skills makes a person wise; what is left after this is play, which is, for the most part, imitative, but by no means serious. For although they are engaging in imitation by various

devices, and by numerous imitations of the body itself that are most unseemly, and by means of words and music in general, and the arts that are born of painting, achieving a great variety of designs of all sorts in various media, imitation does not make anyone wise in any respect, even someone who toils with the utmost diligence.

γὰρ οὖν ἐλέγομεν, πρῶτοι χαιρέτωσαν—ἡ δ' οὖν ἀλφίτων τε καὶ ἀλεύρων ποίησις ἅμα καὶ τροφή καλὴ μὲν καὶ ἀγαθή, σοφὸν δὲ ἄνδρα τελῶς οὐκ ἐθελήσει ποτὲ ἀπεργάσασθαι· τοῦτο γὰρ αὐτό, ἡ τῆς ποιήσεως ἐπὶ κλησις, τῶν ποιουμένων αὐτῶν δυσχέρειαν ἀπεργάζοιτ' ἄν. σχεδὸν δ' οὐδὲ χώρας συμπάσης γεωργία· οὐ γὰρ τέχνη ἀλλὰ φύσει κατὰ θεὸν πάντες φαινόμεθα γῆν μετακεχειρίσθαι. καὶ μὴν οὐδ' ἡ τῶν οἰκίσεών γε συνυφὴ καὶ σύμπασα οἰκοδομία καὶ σκευῶν

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AT: When these have all been excluded, what remains is defence of vast numbers of people by countless means, the most important and extensive being called military skill, the skill of the general, requiring a lot of good fortune, but, by nature, given more to courage than to wisdom. As for the skill of the physician, this is presumably a defence of sorts against the ravages inflicted upon the nature of living creatures by the various seasons with their untimely cold and heat and the like. But none of this is reputed to be wisdom in the truest sense, being devoid of measure and driven by opinion and guesswork. We also refer to steersmen, and sailors too, as defenders, but you would not declare a single man among them to be wise. Those who claim to act as our defenders in lawsuits with their power of speech pay attention to human character by means of memory and experience born of opinion, but they have strayed far from the truth of what is really just.

πάντων ἀπεργαστικῆ, χαλκεία τε καὶ ἡ τῶν τεκτονικῶν καὶ πλαστικῶν καὶ πλεκτικῶν καὶ ἔτι συμπάντων ὀργάνων παρασκευή, δῆμῳ τὸ πρόσφορον ἔχουσα, ἀλλ' οὐκ ἐπ' ἀρετῇ λεγομένη. καὶ μὴν οὐδ' ἡ σύμπασα θηρευτικῆ, πολλή περ καὶ τεχνικὴ γεγονυῖα, τό γε μεγαλοπρεπὲς σὺν τῷ σοφῷ οὐκ ἀποδίδωσιν. οὐ μὴν οὐδὲ μαντικὴ γε

οὐδ' ἐρμηνευτική τὸ παράπαν· τὸ λεγόμενον γὰρ οἶδεν μόνον, εἰ δ' ἀληθές, οὐκ ἔμαθεν. ὅτε δὴ τὴν τῶν ἀναγκαίων ὀρώμεν κτῆσιν διὰ τέχνης μὲν ἀπεργαζομένην, τούτων δὲ οὐδεμίαν οὐδένα σοφὸν ποιοῦσαν, τό γε μετὰ τοῦτο παιδιά τις ἂν λείποιο, μιμητική μὲν τὸ πλεῖστον ἀλλ' οὐδαμῇ σπουδαία. πολλοῖς μὲν γὰρ ὀργάνοις μιμοῦνται, πολλοῖς δ' αὐτῶν τῶν σωμάτων οὐ πάντως εὐσχήμοσι μιμήμασιν, τά τε κατὰ λόγους καὶ μοῦσαν πᾶσαν, καὶ ὅσων γραφικὴ μήτηρ, πολλῶν καὶ παντοίων ποικιλμάτων ἀποτελουμένων ἐν πολλοῖς ὕγρασις καὶ ξηροῖς γένεσιν· ὧν σοφὸν οὐδένα εἰς οὐδὲν σπουδῇ τῇ μεγίστῃ δημιουργοῦντα ἢ μιμητικὴ παρέχεται. πάντων δ' ἐξειργασμένων τὸ λοιπὸν βοήθεια γίγνεται ἂν μυρία μυρίοις, ἢ μὲν μεγίστη τε καὶ εἰς πλεῖστα πολεμικὴ κληθεῖσα, στρατηγικὴ τέχνη, εὐδοκιμωτάτη πρὸς χρεῖαν, εὐτυχίας πλείστης δεομένη, μᾶλλον δὲ ἀνδρεία κατὰ φύσιν ἢ σοφία δεδομένη. ΑΘ. ἦν δὲ καλοῦσι μὲν ἰατρικὴν, βοήθεια δὲ που καὶ αὕτη σχεδὸν ὅσων ὦραι ψύχει καὶ καύματι ἀκαίρῳ καὶ πᾶσι τοῖς τοιούτοις ληίζονται τὴν τῶν ζώων φύσιν. εὐδόκιμον δὲ οὐδὲν τούτων εἰς σοφίαν τὴν ἀληθεστάτην· ἅμετρα γὰρ δόξαι φορεῖται τοπαζόμενα. βοηθοὺς δὲ που καὶ τοὺς κυβερνήτας ἅμα καὶ τοὺς ναύτας ἐροῦμεν, καὶ τούτων ἄνδρα σοφὸν μηδένα τις ἡμᾶς παραμυθούμενος ἐξ ἀπάντων διαγγελλέτω· οὐ γὰρ ἂν εἰδείη τις πνεύματος ὀργὴν οὐδὲ φιλίαν, ὃ προσφιλὲς ἀπάσῃ κυβερνητικῇ. καὶ μὴν οὐδ' ὅπόσοι βοηθοὶ δίκαις ἐν τῇ τοῦ λέγειν ῥώμῃ φασὶ γίγνεσθαι, μνήμη καὶ τριβὴ δόξης ἤθεσιν προσέχοντες τὸν νοῦν, ἀληθείας δὲ τῶν ὄντως δικαίων ἐκτὸς παρεσφαλμένοι. λοιπὴ δ' ἔτι πρὸς δόξαν σοφίας ἐστὶν τις ἄτοπος δύναμις, ἦν φύσιν ἂν οἱ πολλοὶ μᾶλλον ἢ σοφίαν ὀνομάσειαν, τότε ὅταν τινὰ τις συννοῇ ῥαδίως μὲν ὅτιπερ ἂν μανθάνῃ μανθάνοντα,

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AT: But there remains yet an unusual power that is reputed to be wisdom, although most people would call it a natural capacity rather than wisdom. It is noticed in a person who easily learns whatever he is learning, securely commits a lot of material to memory, recalls what is relevant to each situation and what is appropriate, and quickly enacts this. All this is designated by some as a natural capacity, by others as

wisdom, by others as a natural shrewdness, but no sensible person will ever be prepared to call someone truly wise for any of these endowments.

μάλα δὲ πολλὰ καὶ ἀσφαλῶς μνημονεύοντα, ὅταν τε τὸ πρόσφορον ἐκάστῳ διαμνημονεύῃ τις, ὅτι γιγνόμενον ἂν πρέποι, τοῦτο δὲ ταχὺ δρᾷ· ταῦτα γὰρ ἅπαντα οἱ μὲν φύσιν, οἱ δὲ σοφίαν, οἱ δὲ ἀγχίνοιαν θήσουσιν φύσεως, σοφὸν δὲ ὄντως οὐδενὶ τούτων οὐδεὶς τῶν ἐμφρόνων ἐθέλησει ποτὲ καλεῖν. ἀλλὰ μὴν δεῖ φανῆναί γε τινα ἐπιστήμην ἣν ἔχων σοφὸς γίγνοιτ' ἂν ὁ σοφὸς ὄντως ὦν καὶ μὴ μόνον δοξαζόμενος. ἴδωμεν δὴ. χαλεπῷ μὲν γὰρ λόγῳ παντάπασιν

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AT: But surely there must prove to be some knowledge whose possession would constitute the wisdom of the one who is truly wise and does not merely seem so. Let's see. For we are attempting to find, through an extremely difficult argument, another knowledge besides those we have mentioned, a knowledge which may truly and reasonably be described as wisdom, which will render its possessor neither lowly nor simple-minded, by which he will be a wise and good denizen of the city, ruling and being ruled justly, as a fitting citizen. So, let's first look for the one knowledge among all those we have at present, which would render the human race mindless and stupid if it were removed from human nature. There is not much difficulty in seeing what this is. For comparing one with another, so to speak, the knowledge which gives number to the entire mortal race would do this. And it is a god, I believe, rather than good fortune, that saves us by giving this to us.

ἐπιχειροῦμεν, ἐτέραν πάρεξ τῶν εἰρημένων εὐρεῖν, ἥ σοφία μὲν λέγοιτ' ἂν ὄντως τε καὶ εἰκότως, ὁ δὲ λαβὼν οὔτε βάνανσος οὔτ' ἡλίθιος ἔσται, σοφὸς δὲ καὶ ἀγαθὸς δι' αὐτὴν πολίτης τε καὶ ἄρχων καὶ ἀρχόμενος ἐνδίκως ἔσται πόλεως ἅμα καὶ ἐμμελής. κατίδωμεν δὴ ταύτην πρώτην, τίς ποτ' ἐκ τῆς ἀνθρωπίνης φύσεως ἐπιστήμη μία διεξεληθοῦσα ἢ μὴ παραγενομένη τῶν νῦν παρουσῶν ἀνοητότατον ἂν καὶ ἀφρονέστατον

παράσχοιτο ζῶον τὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων. οὐ δὴ τοῦτό γε πάνυ χαλεπὸν τὸ κατιδεῖν. μία γὰρ ὡς εἰπεῖν πρὸς μίαν ἢ τὸν ἀριθμὸν δοῦσα παντὶ τῷ θνητῷ γένει τοῦτ' ἂν δράσειεν· θεὸν δ' αὐτὸν μᾶλλον ἢ τινα τύχην ἡγοῦμαι δόντα ἡμῖν σώζειν ἡμᾶς. ΑΘ. ὃν δὲ θεὸν ἡγοῦμαι, φράζειν χρή, καίπερ ἄτοπον ὄντα, καί πως οὐκ ἄτοπον αὖ· πῶς γὰρ τὸ

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AT: But I believe I should state which god, since it is an unusual one, and somehow, again, not unusual. For how could we ever doubt that the cause of everything that is good for us is also the cause of the greatest good of all, namely understanding? So, Megillus and Clinias, what god am I referring to with such seriousness? Surely it is Uranus whom we are duty bound to honor along with all the other daimons and gods, and to whom above all we should pray. We would all agree that he has been the cause of everything else that is good for us, and we also maintain, correctly, that he has at the same time also given us number, and continues to give this to anyone who is willing to follow along. For once someone embarks upon the correct contemplation of this god, either as the universe, as Olympus or as the heaven, or whatever one pleases to call it, let him only follow how this provides the seasons and sustenance to all as it variegates itself and turns all the courses of the stars within itself. But if someone, having accepted his gift of numbers were to explore the entire circuit of the heaven, this would be the supreme benefit.

ἀγαθῶν αἴτιον ἡμῖν συμπάντων οὐ καὶ τοῦ πολὺ μεγίστου, τῆς φρονήσεως, αἴτιον ἡγεῖσθαι δεῖ γεγονέναι; τίνα δὴ καὶ σεμνύνων ποτὲ λέγω θεόν, ὃ Μέγилλέ τε καὶ Κλεινία; σχεδὸν Οὐρανόν, ὃν καὶ δικαιοτάτον, ὡς σύμπαντες ἄλλοι δαίμονες ἅμα καὶ θεοί, τιμᾶν τε καὶ εὖχεσθαι διαφερόντως αὐτῷ. τὸ δὲ καὶ τῶν ἄλλων αἴτιον ἀγαθῶν πάντων ἡμῖν αὐτὸν γεγονέναι πάντες ἂν ὁμολογοῖμεν· δοῦναι δὲ ἅμα καὶ ἀριθμὸν ἡμεῖς γε ὄντως αὐτόν φαμεν, ἔτι δὲ καὶ δώσειν, ἐάν τις θέλῃ συνακολουθεῖν. ἐὰν γὰρ ἴη τις ἐπὶ θεωρίαν ὀρθὴν τὴν τοῦδε, εἴτε κόσμον εἴτε ὄλυμπον εἴτε οὐρανὸν ἐν ἡδονῇ τῷ λέγειν, λεγέτω μὲν, ἀκολουθεῖτω δὲ ὅπῃ ποικίλλων αὐτόν καὶ τὰ ἐν αὐτῷ στρέφων ἄστρα

πάσας διεξόδους ὥρας τε καὶ τροφὴν πᾶσιν παρέχεται. καὶ τὴν ἄλλην δὲ οὖν φρόνησιν, ὡς φαίμεν ἄν, σὺν ἀριθμῷ παντί, καὶ τᾷλλ' ἀγαθὰ τοῦτο δὲ μέγιστον, ἐάν τις τὴν ἀριθμῶν αὐτοῦ δόσιν δεξάμενος ἐπεξέλθῃ πᾶσαν τὴν περίοδον. ἔτι δὲ σμικρὸν ἐπανελθόντες πῶς τοῖς λόγοις ἀναμνησθῶμεν

977c

AT: Yet, going back a little in the argument, we should recall how right we were to appreciate that if number was indeed removed from human nature, we would never attain any understanding. For the soul of that creature from whom rational discourse is absent could never yet attain total excellence. And a creature that could recognise neither two nor three, odd nor even, and was ignorant of number in general, would never be able to give a rational account of anything of which it had acquired mere sense impressions and memories. There is, however, nothing to prevent it from acquiring the rest of excellence, courage and sound-mindedness. But being deprived of true discourse, no one could ever become wise, and whoever is devoid of wisdom, the greatest part of excellence as a whole, could never become happy because he would not have become perfectly good. And so, it is absolutely necessary that number be the foundation, and not a single skill we mentioned earlier remains once someone does away with the skill of number.

ὅτι καὶ μάλ' ὀρθῶς ἐνόησαμεν ὡς, εἴπερ ἀριθμὸν ἐκ τῆς ἀνθρωπίνης φύσεως ἐξέλοιμεν, οὐκ ἂν ποτέ τι φρόνιμοι γενοίμεθα. οὐ γὰρ ἂν ἔτι ποτέ ψυχὴ τούτου τοῦ ζώου πᾶσαν ἀρετὴν λάβοι σχεδόν, ὅτου λόγος ἀπείη· ζῶον δὲ ὅτι μὴ γινώσκοι δύο καὶ τρία μηδὲ περιττὸν μηδὲ ἄρτιον, ἀγνοοῖ δὲ τὸ παράπαν ἀριθμόν, οὐκ ἂν ποτε διδόναι λόγον ἔχοι περὶ ὧν αἰσθήσεις καὶ μνήμας ἔχοι μόνον εἶη κεκτημένον, τὴν δὲ ἄλλην ἀρετὴν, ἀνδρείαν καὶ σωφροσύνην, οὐδὲν ἀποκωλύει. στερόμενος δὲ ἀληθοῦς λόγου σοφὸς οὐκ ἂν ποτε γένοιτο, ὅτῳ δὲ σοφία μὴ προσείη, πάσης ἀρετῆς τὸ μέγιστον μέρος, οὐκ ἂν ἔτι τελέως ἀγαθὸς γενόμενος εὐδαίμων ποτέ γένοιτο. οὕτως ἀριθμὸν μὲν ἀνάγκη πᾶσα ὑποτίθεσθαι· διότι δὲ τοῦτο ἀνάγκη, λόγος ἔτι πλείων πάντων γίγνεται ἂν τῶν

εἰρημένων. ἀλλὰ καὶ ὁ νῦν ὀρθῶς ῥηθήσεται, ὅτι καὶ τὰ τῶν ἄλλων τεχνῶν λεγόμενα, ἃ νυνδὴ διήλθομεν ἑῶντες εἶναι πάσας τὰς

977e

AT: Someone, having considered the various skills, might perhaps assume that the human race needs number for everyday purposes, although even this is important. But what if someone were to behold both the divine and the mortal aspects of creation, in which reverence and true number will be discovered? Indeed, music in all its aspects obviously requires the enumeration of movements and sounds. And anyone who is to conclude his life in happiness needs to appreciate that any, more or less, irrational, disordered, unseemly, unrhythmical and inharmonious motion, and anything else that involves anything bad, is lacking in all number.

τέχνας, οὐδὲ τούτων ἓν οὐδὲν μένει, πάντα δ' ἀπολείπεται τὸ παράπαν, ὅταν ἀριθμητικὴν τις ἀνέλῃ. ΑΘ. δόξειε δ' ἂν ἴσως τις βραχέων ἕνεκα ἀριθμοῦ δεῖσθαι τὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων γένος, εἰς τὰς τέχνας ἀποβλέψας—καίτοι μέγα μὲν καὶ τοῦτο—εἰ δέ τις ἴδοι τὸ θεῖον τῆς γενέσεως καὶ τὸ θνητόν, ἓν ᾧ καὶ τὸ θεοσεβὲς γνωρισθήσεται καὶ ὁ ἀριθμός

978a

AT: Let us proceed, then, with our enquiry into this very question: how did we learn to use number? Come on then, from where did the one and the two come to us? Now, in many other creatures, the nature enabling them to do this is not even present, and so they are unable to learn how to use number even from the Father. But God first implanted this particular ability in us so that we would be up to the task of understanding what is being shown, and he then showed us, and continues to do so. Of all that is shown to us, what one could be a more beautiful one than the realm of day? We may then come to the night time retaining our vision, where something totally different from it would be presented to us. And as the heaven keeps on revolving these very objects around, through many nights and many days, it keeps on teaching one and two to us humans until even the slowest learner has adequately learned how to use number.

ὄντως, οὐκ ἂν ἔτι πᾶς ἂν τις γνοίῃ σύμπαντα ἀριθμὸν ὅσης ἡμῖν
δυνάμεως αἴτιος ἂν εἴῃ συγγιγνόμενος—ἐπεὶ καὶ τὰ κατὰ μουσικὴν
πᾶσαν διαριθμουμένων κινήσεώς τε καὶ φθόγγων δῆλον ὅτι δεῖ—καὶ
τὸ μέγιστον, ἀγαθῶν ὡς πάντων αἴτιον, ὅτι δὲ κακῶν οὐδενός, εὖ
τοῦτο γνωστότεον, ὃ καὶ τάχα γένοιτ' ἂν. ἀλλ' ἡ σχεδὸν ἀλόγιστος τε καὶ
ἄτακτος ἀσχήμων τε καὶ ἄρρυθμος ἀνάρμοστος τε φορὰ, καὶ πάνθ'
ὅποσα κακοῦ

978b

AT: And, indeed, on seeing these, each of us would also conceive of three and four and many. And as he was fashioning the various objects, God made one of them, the moon, which appears large at one time, smaller at another, as it proceeds on its way, always illuminating a different day, until fifteen days and nights have elapsed. This is its actual orbit if you are prepared to treat a single whole cycle as one, so that even a creature who is very slow to learn would learn this. God, having made the waxing and waning moon, as we have said, also established, in conjunction, the months in relation to the year. And so, as a happy outcome, all creatures began to discern number in relation to number. Through these, the earth brings forth its fruits and harvests for us in order to provide nourishment for all living things, as the winds and rains arise without excess in due measure. But if anything occurs for the worse, contrary to these measures, the divine nature should not be held responsible.

κεκοινώνηκέν τινος, ἐπιλέλειπται παντὸς ἀριθμοῦ, καὶ δεῖ τοῦθ' οὕτω
διανοεῖσθαι τὸν μέλλοντα εὐδαίμονα τελευτήσειν· καὶ τό γε δὴ δίκαιόν
τε καὶ ἀγαθὸν καὶ καλὸν καὶ πάντα τὰ τοιαῦτα οὐδεὶς ποτε μὴ
γινώσκων, ἀληθοῦς δόξης ἐπιλαβόμενος, διαριθμήσεται πρὸς τὸ
ἑαυτὸν τε καὶ ἕτερον πεῖσαι τὸ παράπαν. ἴωμεν δὴ σκεψόμενοι πρὸς
τοῦτ' αὐτό, πῶς ἐμάθομεν ἀριθμεῖν. φέρε· τὸ γὰρ ἔν δὴ καὶ δύο γέγονε
πόθεν ἡμῖν ὥστ' ἐννοῆσαι, φύσιν ταύτην ἔχουσιν ἐκ τοῦ παντὸς πρὸς τὸ
δυνατοῦς ἐννοεῖν εἶναι; πολλοῖς δὲ ἄλλοις αὖ τῶν ζώων οὐδ' εἰς αὐτὸ
τοῦθ' ἡ φύσις παραγέγονεν, ὥστε μαθεῖν δυνατοῖς εἶναι παρὰ τοῦ
πατρὸς ἀριθμεῖν, παρὰ δ' ἡμῖν τοῦτ' αὐτὸ πρῶτον ἐνώκισεν ὁ θεός,

ὥστε ἱκανοῖς εἶναι δεικνύμενον συννοεῖν, ἔπειτ' ἔδειξεν καὶ δείκνυσιν· ὦν τί κάλλιον ἔν ἐνός ἂν τις θεάσαιτο πλην τὸ τῆς ἡμέρας γένος, εἴτα εἰς τὸ τῆς νυκτὸς ἔλθοι μέρος ἔχων ὄψιν, ὅθεν ἕτερον πᾶν αὐτῷ φαίνοιτ' ἂν; καὶ ἐλίττων δὴ ταῦτα αὐτὰ ὅταν μὴ παύηται πολλὰς μὲν νύκτας, πολλὰς δὲ ἡμέρας ἃς οὐρανός, οὐδέποτε παύεται διδάσκων ἀνθρώπους ἔν τε καὶ δύο, πρὶν ἂν καὶ ὁ δυσμαθέστατος ἱκανῶς μάθῃ ἀριθμεῖν· ὥς γὰρ καὶ τρία καὶ τέτταρα καὶ πολλά, ἕκαστος ἡμῶν ἐπινοήσειεν ἂν ὁρῶν ταῦτα. καὶ ἐκ τούτων ἔν ἐποίησεν τὴν σελήνην ὁ θεὸς ἀπεργασάμενος, ἥ τοτὲ μὲν μείζων φαινομένη, τοτὲ δ' ἐλάττων, διεξῆλθεν ἄλλην αἰὲ φαίνουσα ἡμέραν, μέχρι πεντεκαίδεκα ἡμερῶν καὶ νυκτῶν· αὕτη δ' ἔστιν περίοδος, εἰ βούλεται τις τὸν κύκλον ἓνα ὅλον εἰς ἓν τιθέναι, ὥστε ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν καὶ τὸ δυσμαθέστατον ἂν μαθεῖν ζῶον, οἷς παρέδωκεν φύσιν ὁ θεὸς τοῦ δυνατοῖς εἶναι μανθάνειν. ΑΘ. καὶ μέχρι μὲν τούτων τε καὶ ἐν τούτοις σύμπαν τὸ δυνατόν τῶν ζώων μάλα ἀριθμητικὸν γέγονε, τὸ καθ' ἓν αὐτὸ σκοποῦν· τὸ δὲ πρὸς ἄλληλα πάντα ἀριθμὸν αἰὲ λογίζεσθαι, δοκῶ μὲν μείζονος ἕνεκα, καὶ τούτου δὲ σελήνην, καθάπερ εἵπομεν, αὐξανομένην καὶ φθίνουσαν ἐμποιήσας, μῆνας πρὸς τὸν ἐνιαυτὸν συνεστήσατο, καὶ πάντα ἀριθμὸν πρὸς ἀριθμὸν ἥρξατο συνορᾶν εὐδαίμονι τύχῃ. διὰ δὲ ταῦθ' ἡμῖν καρποὶ τε καὶ ἐγκύμων ἡ γῆ γέγονεν, ὥστ' εἶναι τροφὴν πᾶσι τοῖς ζώοις, ἀνέμων τε καὶ ὑετῶν γιγνομένων οὐκ ἐξαισίων οὐδὲ ἀμέτρων· ἀλλ' εἴ τι παρὰ ταῦτα γίγνεται πρὸς τὸ φλαῦρον, οὐ τὴν θείαν ἀλλὰ τὴν ἀνθρωπίνην αἰτιᾶσθαι χρὴ φύσιν, οὐκ ἐν δίκῃ διανέμουςαν τὸν αὐτῶν βίον. ἡμῖν δ' οὖν ζητοῦσιν περὶ νόμων σχεδὸν ἔδοξεν τὰ μὲν ἄλλα ῥάδιά τ' εἶναι γινῶναι τὰ βέλτιστα ἀνθρώποις, καὶ πᾶς ἂν ἱκανὸς γίγνεσθαι καὶ συνεῖναι τὰ λεγόμενα καὶ ποιεῖν, εἰ γνοίῃ τί ποτ' ἔστιν ὁ συμφέρειν εἰκὸς καὶ τί τὸ μὴ συμφέρον· ἔδοξε δὴ καὶ νῦν ἔτι δοκεῖ τὰ

979c

AT: Now, in our enquiry into laws, it seemed to be easy, in general, to understand what is best for humanity. It seemed then, and still seems now, that all the other pursuits are not particularly difficult, but the question of how we are to become good people is extremely difficult. And everyone agrees with everyone else that the soul should be good,

and about the way in which it should be good. It should be just, sound-minded and courageous, and everyone maintains that it should be wise too, but as to the sort of wisdom, as we have already explained, no one agrees at all with anyone else in most cases. Now, however, we are discovering, besides all the previous wisdoms, another one which is not without its uses for certain purposes: whoever has learned the subjects we have outlined seems to be wise. But whether the person who is knowledgeable in these subjects is indeed wise and good, is a question that needs to be decided.

μὲν ἄλλα ἐπιτηδεύματα πάντα οὐ σφόδρα χαλεπὰ εἶναι, τὸ δὲ τίνα τρόπον χρή γίγνεσθαι χρηστοὺς ἀνθρώπους παγχάλεπον. καὶ τὰ μὲν ἄλλα αὖ πάντα κτᾶσθαι χρηστά, τὸ λεγόμενόν τε, καὶ δυνατόν καὶ οὐ χαλεπόν, οὐσίαν τε ὅσῃν δεῖ καὶ μὴ δεῖ, καὶ σῶμα οἷόν τε δεῖ καὶ μὴ καὶ ψυχὴν ὅτι μὲν ἀγαθὴν δεῖ, συγχωρεῖ πᾶς παντί, τὸ δ' ὄντινα τρόπον ἀγαθὴν, ὅτι μὲν αὖ δικαίαν καὶ σώφρονα καὶ ἀνδρείαν, καὶ ταῦτα, ὅτι δὲ σοφὴν, φησὶ μὲν πᾶς δεῖν, ἥντινα δὲ σοφίαν, ὡς ἄρτι διεληλύθαμεν, οὐδεὶς οὐδενὶ τὸ παράπαν ἔτι συνομολογεῖ τῶν πολλῶν. νῦν οὖν δὴ παρὰ πάσας τὰς πρόσθεν σοφίας οὐ φαύλην τινὰ ἀνευρίσκομεν εἰς αὐτά γε ταῦτα, τὸ δοκεῖν σοφὸν εἶναι τὸν γε μεμαθηκότα ἅπερ καὶ διεληλύθαμεν· εἰ δ' ἔστιν σοφὸς ὁ ταῦτ' ἐπιστήμων καὶ ἀγαθός, τούτου δὴ περί λόγον δεῖ λαβεῖν. ΚΛ. ὦ ξέने, ὡς εἰκότως εἶπες ὅτι περὶ μεγάλων μεγάλα ἐπιχειρεῖς φράζειν.

979e

CL: How right you were, stranger, to say that we are trying to come up with important formulations on important issues.

979e

AT: Indeed, Clinias, the issues are not trivial, but the greater difficulty is that the formulations are to be completely true in every way.

979e

CL: Very much so, stranger, but you should not tire of saying what you are saying.

979e

AT: Yes, and you two are to keep on listening.

979e

CL: Granted. I am answering on behalf of both of us.

ΑΘ. οὐ γὰρ σμικρά, ὦ Κλεινία· τὸ δὲ χαλεπώτερον, ὅτι παντάπασι καὶ πάντως ἀληθῆ. ΚΛ. σφόδρα γε, ὦ ξένε· ἀλλ' ὅμως μὴ ἀποκάμης λέγων ὁ φής. ΑΘ. ναί, μηδὲ σφὼ τοίνυν ἀκούοντε. ΚΛ. ταῦτ' ἔσται καὶ ὑπὲρ ἀμφοῖν ἐγὼ σοι φράζω.

980a

AT: Very well. To begin with then, we need to say, first and foremost, it appears, most of all, whether or not we are able to capture in a single word what we think wisdom is. But if this proves quite impossible for us, we should say, secondly, what, and what kinds of wisdom, would, according to our account, make a person wise, if he were to acquire them.

980a

CL: Please proceed.

980a

AT: After this, no reproach will ever be incurred by the lawgiver for presenting a likeness of the gods that is nobler and better than any that have been presented previously, having recourse to a sort of noble game, honouring the gods and celebrating them with hymns and happiness throughout his own life.

ΑΘ. καλῶς. ἔξ ἀρχῆς δὴ ῥητέον ἀνάγκη πρῶτον, ὡς φαίνεται, μάλιστα μὲν ἄν, εἰ δυνάμεθα ἐνὶ λαβεῖν ὀνόματι, τίς ἐστὶν ἣν οἴομεθα σοφίαν εἶναι, τοῦτο δ' εἰ σφόδρα ἀδυνατοῦμεν, τὸ δεύτερον, τίνες εἰσὶν ποτε καὶ ὁπόσαι τινές, ἅς τις λαβὼν σοφὸς ἂν εἴη κατὰ τὸν ἡμέτερον μῦθον. ΚΛ. λέγοις ἄν. ΑΘ. τὸ δὴ μετὰ τοῦτο ἀνεμέσητον τῷ νομοθέτῃ τὸ κάλλιον τῶν πρότερον εἰρημένων περὶ θεῶν καὶ ἄμεινον ἀπεικάζοντι λέγειν, οἷον παιδιᾶ καλῇ χρωμένῳ καὶ τιμῶντι

980b

CL: Well said, stranger. Let this indeed be the objective of your laws: that the life be lived in greater purity, praising the gods, and that it

may end in nobility and supreme goodness.

980b

AT: So, Clinias, how are we to describe this? Do you think we should honour the gods by singing heartfelt hymns, praying that the noblest and best words will come to us? Is this the way? Or what do you think?

θεοὺς, ὕμνοις τε καὶ εὐδαιμονίᾳ γεραίροντι διάγειν τὸν αὐτοῦ βίον. ΚΛ. ἢ καλῶς, ὦ ξένε, λέγεις. εἰ γάρ σοι τοῦτο τέλος εἴη τῶν νόμων, θεοὺς προσπαίσαντι καθαρώτερον δὲ διαγαγόντι τὸν βίον τῆς ἅμα τελευτῆς ἀρίστης τε καὶ καλλίστης τυχεῖν. ΑΘ. πῶς οὖν, ὦ Κλεινία, λέγομεν; ἢ δοκεῖ τοὺς θεοὺς ὕμνουντες σφόδρα τιμῶμεν, εὐχόμενοι τὰ κάλλιστα καὶ ἄριστα περὶ αὐτῶν ἐπιέναι λέγειν ἡμῖν; οὕτως ἢ πῶς λέγεις;

980c

CL: Yes, that's a wonderful way to proceed. So, good man, have faith in the gods, utter your prayers, and then speak the beautiful words that come to you about the gods and goddesses.

980c

AT: It shall be so provided if the god himself guides us. Just join in the prayer.

980c

CL: Speak on.

980c

AT: Well firstly, since our predecessors did such a bad job of describing the origin of gods and mortal creatures, it is necessary for me first to express this better, based upon my previous argument, resuming what I was trying to say to the impious folk. I was saying that there are gods who care for all things great and small, and who are more or less incapable of persuasion in matters of justice. The most important of these statements was that any soul would be elder than any body. This must surely be the case, for it is plausible that the better, more ancient and more godlike be elder than the young, the younger and the less honourable, and that the ruler be elder in every respect than the ruled, and the leader than the led. Let us understand, then, that soul is elder

than body. But if this is the case, our starting point would constitute a more plausible basis for the starting point of creation, and we could then propose that we are embarking aright upon the greatest wisdom, that which concerns the origin of gods.

ΚΛ. θαυμαστώς μὲν οὖν οὕτως. ἀλλ', ὦ δαιμόνιε, πιστεύσας τοῖς θεοῖς εὐχου τε καὶ λέγε τὸν ἐπιόντα σοι λόγον τῶν καλῶν περὶ τοὺς θεοὺς τε καὶ τὰς θεάς. ΑΘ. ἔσται ταῦτα, ἂν αὐτὸς ὁ θεὸς ἡμῖν ὑφηγῇται. συνεύχου μόνον. ΚΛ. λέγοις ἂν τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο. ΑΘ. θεογονίαν τοίνυν καὶ ζωογονίαν ἀναγκαῖον, ὡς ἔοικεν, πρῶτόν μοι, κακῶς ἀπεικασάντων τῶν ἔμπροσθεν, βέλτιον ἀπεικάσαι κατὰ τὸν ἔμπροσθεν λόγον, ἀναλαβόντα ὃν πρὸς τοὺς ἀσεβεῖς ἐπικεχείρηκα λέγων, φράζων ὡς εἰσὶν θεοὶ ἐπιμελούμενοι πάντων, μικρῶν καὶ μεγάλων, καὶ σχεδὸν ἀπαραμύθητοι τῶν περὶ τὰ δίκαιά εἰσιν πράγματα— εἰ δὴ μέμνησθέ γε, ὦ Κλεινία· ἐλάβετε μὲν γὰρ δὴ καὶ ὑπομνήματα—καὶ γὰρ ἦν τὰ ῥηθέντα τότε καὶ μάλα ἀληθῆ· τόδε δὲ αὐτῶν ἦν τὸ μέγιστον, ὅτι πρεσβύτερον εἶη ψυχῇ σώματος ἅπαντα παντός—ἄρα μέμνησθε; ἢ πάντως που τοῦτο γε; —ὁ γὰρ ἄμεινον καὶ παλαιότερον καὶ θεοειδέστερον, πιθανὸν ὅτι τοῦ νέου καὶ νεωτέρου καὶ ἀτιμότερου, πανταχῇ τε ἄρχον ἀρχομένου πρεσβύτερον καὶ ἄγον ἀγομένου πάντη. λάβωμεν δὴ τοῦτό γε, ὡς ψυχῇ πρεσβυτέρον ἐστὶ σώματος.

981a

CL: Let it be so. We have spoken as best we can.

981a

AT: Come on, then. Should we declare that a living creature may most truly be described, according to its nature, as a combination of soul and body coming together to give rise to a single form?

981a

CL: Correct.

981a

AT: Is something of this sort then rightly called a living creature?

981a

CL: Yes.

ΑΘ. εἰ δ' ἔχει τοῦτο οὕτως, τό γε πρῶτον ἡμῖν τοῦ πρώτου τῆς γενέσεως πιθανώτερον ἂν εἴη σχεδὸν ὑπεργγμένον· καὶ θῶμεν δὴ τὴν ἀρχὴν τῆς ἀρχῆς εὐσχημονέστερον ἔχειν, καὶ τῶν μεγίστων σοφίας περὶ θεῶν γενέσεως ὀρθότατα ἐπιβαίνειν ἡμᾶς. ΚΛ. ἔστω ταῦτα εἰς δύναμιν λεγόμενα. ΑΘ. φέρε δὴ, ζῶόν γε ἀληθέστατα λέγεσθαι κατὰ φύσιν φῶμεν τοῦτο γε, ὅταν μία συνελθοῦσα σύστασις ψυχῆς καὶ σώματος ἀποτεκῇ μίαν μορφήν; ΚΛ. ὀρθῶς.

981b

AT: Well, according to the likely account, we should say that there are five solid bodies from which the best and most exalted things may be moulded, while the other kind, in its entirety, has a single form. For nothing could be bodiless and always entirely devoid of colour, apart from the truly most divine kind, which is soul. To this alone, we may say, belongs the function of moulding and fashioning. Now, we should declare that there is fire and water, that air is third, earth fourth, and ether fifth, and that every creature is perfected in complexity and variety by the relative predominance of these bodies. We should propose that the first one is earthy, consisting of all humans, all creatures with many feet, those without feet, those that are mobile, and those that are immobile, being held fast by their roots. We should also propose that there is another type of living creature that consists mostly of fire. And so we should declare that various living creatures, also visible, arise from these constituents, and we should think of them as the race of the creatures of the heavens, which, we should declare, constitute collectively the divine race of stars, each possessed of a perfect body and the happiest and very best soul.

ΑΘ. ζῶον μὲν δὴ τὸ τοιοῦτον καλεῖται δικαιοτάτα; ΚΛ. ναί. ΑΘ. στερεὰ δὲ σώματα λέγεσθαι χρή κατὰ τὸν εἰκότα λόγον πέντε, ἐξ ὧν κάλλιστα καὶ ἄριστά τις ἂν πλάττοι, τὸ δὲ ἄλλο γένος ἅπαν ἔχει μορφήν μίαν· οὐ γάρ ἐστιν ἀσώματον ὅτι τ' ἄλλο γίγνεται ἂν καὶ χρῶμα οὐδὲν οὐδαμῶς οὐδέποτε ἔχον, πλὴν τὸ θεϊότατον ὄντως ψυχῆς γένος. τοῦτο δ' ἐστὶ σχεδὸν ὥς μόνῳ πλάττειν καὶ δημιουργεῖν προσήκει, σώματι δέ, ὃ λέγομεν, πλάττεσθαι καὶ γίνεσθαι καὶ ὁρᾶσθαι τῷ δέ—λέγωμεν πάλιν·

οὐ γὰρ ἅπαξ ῥητέον—ἀοράτῳ τε εἶναι καὶ γινώσκοντι νοητῷ τε, μνήμης μεταλαμβάνοντι λογισμοῦ τε ἐν περιτταῖς τε καὶ ἀρτίαις ἅμα μεταβολαῖς. πέντε οὖν ὄντων τῶν σωμάτων, πῦρ χρή φάναι καὶ ὕδωρ εἶναι καὶ τρίτον ἀέρα, τέταρτον δὲ γῆν, πέμπτον δὲ αἰθέρα, τούτων δ' ἐν ἡγεμονίαις ἕκαστον ζῶον πολὺ καὶ παντοδαπὸν ἀποτελεῖσθαι. μαθεῖν δὲ καθ' ἐν ᾧδ' ἔστιν χρεῶν. γήινον μὲν τιθῶμεν τὸ πρῶτον ἡμῖν ἐν, πάντας μὲν ἀνθρώπους, πάντα δὲ ὅσα πολύποδα καὶ ἄποδα, καὶ ὅσα πορεύσιμα καὶ ὅσα μόνιμα, διεilhaμμένα ρίζαις· τὸ δὲ ἐν αὐτοῦ τόδε νομίζειν δεῖ, ὥς πάντα μὲν ἐξ ἀπάντων ταῦτ' ἔστιν τῶν γενῶν, τὸ δὲ πολὺ τούτου γῆς ἔστιν καὶ τῆς στερεμνίας φύσεως. ἄλλο δὲ χρή ζῶου γένος θεῖναι δεύτερον γιγνόμενον ἅμα καὶ δυνατὸν ὁρᾶσθαι· τὸ γὰρ πλεῖστον πυρὸς ἔχει, ἔχει μὴν γῆς

981e

AT: So let us, in the first place, bear in mind that, according to us, there are two living beings of this sort: both are visible, although one seems to be composed wholly of fire, the other of earth. The earthy one moves in a disorderly manner, while the one composed of fire moves in perfect order. The one that moves in a disorderly manner should be thought of as unintelligent, acting for the most part like the living creatures about us. The one that maintains an orderly course in heaven should provide us with great evidence of being intelligent. Indeed, by constantly proceeding, acting, and being acted upon in the same way without variation, it would be providing sufficient evidence of living in an intelligent way.

τε καὶ ἀέρος, ἔχει δὲ καὶ ἀπάντων τῶν ἄλλων βραχέα μέρη, διὸ δὴ ζῶά τε ἐξ αὐτῶν παντοδαπά γίγνεσθαι χρή φάναι καὶ ὁρώμενα, νομίσει δὲ δὴ δεῖ πάλιν τὰ κατ' οὐρανὸν ζώων γένη, ὃ δὴ πᾶν χρή φάναι θεῖον γένος ἄστρων γεγονέναι, σώματος μὲν τυχὸν καλλίστου, ψυχῆς δ' εὐδαιμονεστάτης τε καὶ ἀρίστης. δυοῖν δὲ αὐτοῖς μοιρῶν τὴν ἑτέραν χρή δόξῃ μεταδιδόναι σχεδόν· ἥ γὰρ ἀνώλεθρόν τε καὶ ἀθάνατον ἕκαστον αὐτῶν εἶναι καὶ θεῖον τὸ παράπαν ἐξ ἀπάσης ἀνάγκης, ἥ τινα μακραιώνα βίον ἔχειν ἱκανὸν ἐκάστῳ ζωῆς, ἥς οὐδέν τι πλείονος ἂν προσδεῖσθαι ποτε. ΑΘ. νοήσωμεν οὖν πρῶτον, ὃ λέγομεν, δύο τὰ

τοιαῦτα εἶναι ζῶα—πάλιν γὰρ λέγωμεν—όρατὰ μὲν ἀμφοτέρω, τὸ μὲν ἐκ πυρός, ὡς δόξειεν ἄν, ὅλον, τὸ δ' ἐκ γῆς, καὶ τὸ μὲν γήινον ἐν ἀταξίᾳ, τὸ δ' ἐκ πυρὸς ἐν τάξει πάσῃ κινούμενον. τὸ μὲν οὖν ἐν ἀταξίᾳ κινούμενον ἄφρον χρηρ νομίζουσιν, ὅπερ ὡς τὸ πολὺ δρᾷ τὸ περὶ ἡμᾶς ζῶον, τὸ δὲ ἐν τάξει τε καὶ οὐρανῷ πόρον ἔχον μέγα τεκμήριον χρηρ ποιεῖσθαι τοῦ φρόνιμον εἶναι· κατὰ ταῦτα γὰρ ἂν καὶ ὡσαύτως πορευόμενον αἰεὶ καὶ ποιοῦν καὶ πάσχον τεκμήριον ἱκανὸν τοῦ φρονίμως ζῆν εἴη παρεχόμενον. ἡ ψυχῆς δὲ ἀνάγκη νοῦν κεκτημένης ἀπασῶν ἀναγκῶν πολὺ μεγίστη γίγνοιτ' ἂν—ἄρχουσα γὰρ ἄλλ' οὐκ ἀρχομένη νομοθετεῖ—τὸ δὲ ἀμετάστροφον, ὅταν ψυχὴ τὸ

982c

AT: Soul has made the best decision in accord with supreme reason, the result is unalterable and complete, truly in accord with reason, and not even adamant could ever prove stronger or more unalterable than this. But, in fact, three Fates hold fast and keep watch to ensure the completion of whatever has been decided with perfect deliberation by any of the gods. For humanity, there should have been adequate proof that the stars and their entire proceedings are possessed of reason in the fact that they always do the same things because they are acting out deliberations of ancient date, made a wondrously long time ago. This conclusion of ours is the very opposite of what most people believe. They think that whatever does the same things without variation does not possess soul. Hence, most people assume that humans are intelligent and alive because they are moving, while the divine race is unintelligent because its orbits remain the same. But humanity could have relied upon the more beautiful, the better, the friendly to understand that whatever is the same and unvarying and always acts accordingly should, for this very reason, be regarded as intelligent. Such is the nature of the stars, most beautiful to behold, as they dance the most beautiful and exalted dance movement of all.

ἄριστον κατὰ τὸν ἄριστον βουλευέσθαι νοῦν, τὸ τέλος ἐκβαίνει τῷ ὄντι κατὰ νοῦν, καὶ οὐδὲ ἀδάμας ἂν αὐτοῦ κρεῖττον οὐδὲ ἀμεταστροφώτερον ἂν ποτε γένοιτο, ἀλλ' ὄντως τρεῖς Μοῖραι

κατέχουσαι φυλάττουσι τέλεον εἶναι τὸ βελτίστη βουλῇ βεβουλευμένον ἐκάστοις θεῶν. τοῖς δὲ ἀνθρώποις ἐχρῆν τεκμήριον εἶναι τοῦ νοῦν ἔχειν ἄστρα τε καὶ σύμπασαν ταύτην τὴν διαπορείαν, ὅτι τὰ αὐτὰ αἰὲν πράττει διὰ τὸ βεβουλευμένα πάλοι πράττειν θαυμαστόν τινα χρόνον ὅσον, ἀλλ' οὐ μεταβουλευόμενον ἄνω καὶ κάτω, τοτὲ μὲν ἕτερα, ἄλλοτε δὲ ἄλλα πράττον, πλανᾶσθαι τε καὶ μετακυκλεῖσθαι. τοῦθ' ἡμῶν τοῖς πολλοῖς αὐτὸ τοῦναντίον ἔδοξεν, ὅτι τὰ αὐτὰ καὶ ὡσαύτως πράττει, ψυχὴν οὐκ ἔχειν· οὕτω τοῖς ἄφροσι συνεφέσπετο τὸ πλῆθος, ὥς τὸ μὲν ἀνθρώπινον ἔμφρον καὶ ζῶν ὡς κινούμενον ὑπολαβεῖν, τὸ δὲ θεῖον ἄφρον ὡς μένον ἐν ταῖς αὐταῖς φοραῖς· ἐξῆν δὲ ἀνθρώπῳ γε ἐπὶ τὰ καλλίῳ καὶ βελτίῳ καὶ φίλῳ τιθεμένῳ λαμβάνειν ὡς διὰ τοῦτο αὐτὸ ἔμφρον δεῖ νομίζειν τὸ κατὰ ταῦτα καὶ ὡσαύτως καὶ διὰ ταῦτα πράττον αἰεὶ, τοῦτο δ' εἶναι τὴν τῶν ἄστρον φύσιν, ἰδεῖν μὲν καλλίστην, πορείαν δὲ καὶ χορείαν πάντων χορῶν καλλίστην καὶ μεγαλοπρεπεστάτην χορεύοντα πᾶσι τοῖς ζῶσι τὸ δέον ἀποτελεῖν. ΑΘ. καὶ μὴν ὅτι γε δικαίως

983a

AT: And, indeed, to justify our claim that they have souls, we should first consider their size. For they are not small as they appear to be; each of them is, rather, of enormous bulk. Indeed, it is possible to appreciate correctly that the sun as a whole is larger than the entire earth, and that all the moving stars are possessed of wondrous magnitude. Well, I maintain that God will be the cause of their revolutions, otherwise this is not possible at all. For as we have shown, nothing could ever become ensouled except through God. It is not possible that earth and the heaven, all of the stars and the complete masses formed from them, should proceed with such precision by the year, the month and the day, and that all these happenings benefit all of us, without soul being present to each, or, indeed, in each of them.

ἔμψυχα αὐτὰ λέγομεν, πρῶτον τὸ μέγεθος αὐτῶν διανοηθῶμεν. οὐ γάρ, ὡς σμικρὰ φαντάζεται, τηλικαῦτα ὄντως ἐστίν, ἀλλ' ἀμήχανον ἕκαστον αὐτῶν τὸν ὄγκον—πιστεῦσαι δ' ἄξιον· ἀποδείξουσιν γὰρ ἱκαναῖς λαμβάνεται—τὸν γὰρ ἥλιον ὅλον τῆς γῆς ὅλης μείζω διανοηθῆναι

δυνατὸν ὀρθῶς, καὶ πάντα δὴ τὰ φερόμενα ἄστρα θαυμαστόν τι μέγεθος ἔχει. λάβωμεν δὴ τίς τρόπος ἂν εἴη τοσοῦτον περιφέρειν ὄγκον τινὰ φύσιν τὸν αὐτὸν ἀεὶ χρόνον, ὅσον καὶ νῦν περιφέρεται. θεὸν δὴ φημι τὸν αἴτιον ἔσσεσθαι, καὶ οὐποθ' ἐτέρως εἶναι δυνατόν· ἔμψυχον μὲν γὰρ οὐποτε γένοιτ' ἂν ἐτέρα πλὴν διὰ θεόν, ὥς ἡμεῖς ἀπεφηνάμεθα. ὅτε δὲ τοῦτο οἶός τέ ἐστιν θεός, ἅπανα αὐτῷ ῥαστώνη γέγονεν τοῦ πρώτου μὲν ζῶον γεγονέναι πᾶν σῶμα καὶ ὄγκον σύμπαντα, ἔπειτα, ἥπερ ἂν διανοηθῇ βέλτιστα, ταύτη φέρειν. νῦν δὴ περὶ ἀπάντων τούτων ἓνα λόγον λέγοιμεν ἀληθῆ· οὐκ ἔστιν γῆν τε καὶ οὐρανὸν ἅπαντάς τε ἀστέρας ὄγκους τε ἐκ τούτων σύμπαντας, μὴ ψυχῆς πρὸς ἐκάστω γενομένης ἢ καὶ ἐν ἐκάστοις, εἴτα εἰς ἀκρίβειαν κατ' ἐνιαυτὸν οὕτω πορεύεσθαι κατὰ μῆνας τε καὶ ἡμέρας, καὶ σύμπαντα τὰ γιγνόμενα σύμπασιν ἡμῖν ἀγαθὰ γίνεσθαι. δεῖ δέ, ὅσω φλαυρότερόν ἐστ' ἄνθρωπος, μὴ τοι ληροῦντά γε, σαφῶς δέ τι λέγοντα φαίνεσθαι. ῥύμας μὲν οὖν εἴ τις αἰτίας τινὰς ἐρεῖ σωμάτων ἢ φύσεις ἢ τι τοιοῦτον, οὐδὲν σαφές ἐρεῖ· τὸ δὲ παρ' ἡμῶν εἰρημένον

983d

AT: Insofar as a human being is debased, it is necessary that he avoid mere blabbering and prove to be speaking sensibly. Now, anyone who speaks of the surges or natures of bodies as causes will not be talking sense. Firstly, there are two things, body and soul, and there are many instances of each; there is no third thing common to both, and, finally, soul is distinct from body. We shall propose that one is presumably intelligent, the other devoid of intelligence, one rules while the other is ruled, one is the cause of all while the other is not the cause of any effect. And so, it is most foolish and unreasonable to maintain that whatever is in the heaven has come into being by some other agency, and is not the product of soul and body as we say it is. Now, if our arguments about everything of this sort are to prevail, one or the other of two things must be said of them: either they are to be glorified as actual gods, or they are to be understood as images of gods, created representations, fashioned by the gods themselves.

σφόδρ' ἀναλαβεῖν χρή, πότερον ἔχει λόγον ὁ λόγος ἢ πάντως ὕστερεϊ, τὸ πρῶτον μὲν τὰ ὄντα εἶναι δύο, τὸ μὲν ψυχὴν, τὸ δὲ σῶμα, καὶ πολλὰ ἐκατέρου, πάντα δὲ ἀλλήλων ἄλλα καὶ ἑκάτερα ἐκατέρων, καὶ τρίτον ἄλλο οὐδὲν κοινὸν οὐδενί, διαφέρειν δὲ ψυχὴν σώματος. ἔμφρον μὲν που, τὸ δὲ ἄφρον θήσομεν, ἄρχον δέ, τὸ δὲ ἀρχόμενον, καὶ τὸ μὲν αἴτιον ἀπάντων, τὸ δὲ ἀναίτιον πάσης πάθης· ὥστε τά γε δὴ κατ' οὐρανὸν ὑπ' ἄλλου του φάναι γεγονέναι, καὶ μὴ ψυχῆς τε καὶ σώματος οὕτως εἶναι γεννήματα, πολλὴ μωρία τε καὶ ἀλογία. εἰ δ' οὖν δεῖ νικᾶν τοὺς περὶ ἀπάντων τῶν τοιούτων λόγους καὶ πιστῶς θεῖα φαίνεσθαι γεγονέναι τὰ τοιαῦτα σύμπαντα, δυοῖν τοι θάτερα θετέον αὐτά· ΑΘ. ἢ γὰρ θεοὺς αὐτοὺς ταῦτα ὑμνητέον ὀρθότατα, ἢ θεῶν εἰκόνας ὡς ἀγάλματα ὑπολαβεῖν γεγονέναι, θεῶν αὐτῶν ἐργασαμένων· οὐ γὰρ ἀνοήτων γε οὐδὲ βραχέος ἀξίων, ἀλλ' ὅπερ εἰρήκαμεν, τούτων ἡμῖν θάτερα θετέα, τὰ δὲ τεθέντα τιμητέον πάντων ἀγαλμάτων διαφερόντως· οὐ γὰρ μήποτε φανῇ καλλίω καὶ κοινότερα συμπάντων ἀνθρώπων ἀγάλματα, οὐδ' ἐν διαφέρουσιν τόποις ἰδρυμένα, καθαριότητι καὶ σεμνότητι καὶ συμπάσῃ

984b

AT: Now, in relation to gods, we should undertake this much: having discerned two kinds of creature, both visible – one, we maintain, being immortal, the other, the earthy, being mortal – we should attempt to speak of the three that are in between these two, the middle three of the five, doing so with the utmost clarity based upon reasoned opinion. Indeed, we should place ether above fire and propose that soul fashions, from this, living creatures possessing power belonging for the most part to the nature of ether. After ether, we should propose that soul fashions a different kind of creature from air, and a third from water. And soul, having wrought all these, is likely to have filled the entire heaven full of living creatures using all five kinds according to their power, all having come into being partaking of life. These are second, third, fourth and fifth in descent from the manifest gods, ending with us humans.

ζωῇ διαφέροντα ἢ ταύτη ὡς πάντη ταύτη γεγένηται. νῦν οὖν δὴ περὶ θεῶν ἐγχειρῶμεν τό γε τοσοῦτον, τὰ δύο κατιδόντες ζῶα ὁρατὰ ἡμῖν, ἃ φαμεν ἀθάνατον, τὸ δὲ γήινον ἅπαν θνητὸν γεγονέναι, τὰ τρία τὰ μέσα τῶν πέντε τὰ μεταξὺ τούτων σαφέστατα κατὰ δόξαν τὴν ἐπεικῇ γεγονότα πειραθῆναι λέγειν. αἰθέρα μὲν γὰρ μετὰ τὸ πῦρ θῶμεν, ψυχὴν δ' ἐξ αὐτοῦ τιθῶμεν πλάττειν ζῶα δύναμιν ἔχοντα, ὥσπερ

984c

AT: As for the gods such as Zeus, Hera and all the others, anyone may propose whatever they wish, but in accordance with the same convention. The visible gods, then, the greatest, the most honoured, the keenest of sight, must be said to be first. These are the stars and whatever else we observe among their cohort. After these and below these in order are the daimons, the airy type, occupying the third and middle position, responsible for interpretation, whom we should greatly honour in our prayers to ensure that they convey auspicious messages. Partaking of a wondrous intelligence, since they constitute a race that learns and remembers with ease, we should declare that they are aware of the entire content of our minds, take delight in the noble and good, and hate the utterly ignoble since they do share in the experience of pain. And the heaven has been filled full of living creatures, who all interpret towards one another and towards all the supreme gods.

τῶν ἄλλων γενῶν, τὸ πολὺ μὲν τῆς αὐτοῦ φύσεως, τὰ δὲ σμικρότερα συνδέσμου χάριν ἐκ τῶν ἄλλων γενῶν· μετὰ δὲ τὸν αἰθέρα ἐξ ἄερος πλάττειν τὴν ψυχὴν γένος ἕτερον ζώων, καὶ τὸ τρίτον ἐξ ὕδατος. πάντα δὲ δημιουργήσασαν ταῦτα ψυχὴν ζώων εἰκὸς ὅλον οὐρανὸν ἐμπλησαι, χρησαμένην πᾶσι τοῖς γένεσι κατὰ δύναμιν, πάντων μὲν μετόχων τοῦ ζῆν γεγονότων· δεύτερα δὲ καὶ τρίτα καὶ τέταρτα καὶ πέμπτα, ἀπὸ θεῶν τῶν φανερῶν ἀρξάμενα γενέσεως, εἰς ἡμᾶς τοὺς ἀνθρώπους ἀποτελευτᾶν. θεοὺς μὲν δὴ, Δία τε καὶ Ἥραν καὶ τοὺς ἄλλους πάντας, ὅπη τις ἐθέλει, ταύτη κατὰ τὸν αὐτὸν τιθέσθω νόμον καὶ πάγιον ἐχέτω τοῦτον τὸν λόγον· θεοὺς δὲ δὴ τοὺς ὁρατοὺς, μεγίστους καὶ τιμιωτάτους καὶ ὀξύτατον ὁρῶντας πάντη, τοὺς πρώτους τὴν τῶν

ἄστρον φύσιν λεκτέον καὶ ὅσα μετὰ τούτων αἰσθανόμεθα γεγονότα, μετὰ δὲ τούτους καὶ ὑπὸ τούτοις ἐξῆς δαίμονας, ἀέριον δὲ γένος, ἔχον ἔδραν τρίτην καὶ μέσην, τῆς ἐρμηνείας αἴτιον, εὐχαῖς τιμᾶν μάλα χρεῶν χάριν τῆς εὐφήμου διαπορείας. ΑΘ. τῶν δὲ δύο τούτων ζώων, τοῦ τ' ἐξ αἰθέρος ἐφεξῆς τε ἀέρος ὄν, διορώμενον ὅλον αὐτῶν ἐκάτερον εἶναι—παρὸν δὴ πλησίον οὐ κατάδηλον ἡμῖν γίνεσθαι—μετέχοντα δὲ φρονήσεως θαυμαστῆς, ἅτε γένους ὄντα εὐμαθοῦς τε καὶ μνήμονος, γινώσκειν μὲν σύμπασαν τὴν ἡμετέραν αὐτὰ διάνοιαν λέγωμεν, καὶ τόν τε καλὸν ἡμῶν καὶ ἀγαθὸν ἅμα θαυμαστῶς ἀσπάζεσθαι καὶ τὸν σφόδρα κακὸν μισεῖν, ἅτε λύπης μετέχοντα ἤδη—θεὸν μὲν γὰρ δὴ τὸν τέλος ἔχοντα τῆς θείας μοίρας ἔξω τούτων εἶναι, λύπης τε καὶ ἡδονῆς, τοῦ δὲ φρονεῖν καὶ τοῦ γινώσκειν κατὰ πάντα μετεिल्φέναι— καὶ συμπλήρους δὴ ζώων οὐρανοῦ γεγονότος, ἐρμηνεύεσθαι πρὸς ἀλλήλους τε καὶ τοὺς ἀκροτάτους θεοὺς πάντας τε καὶ πάντα, διὰ τὸ φέρεσθαι τὰ μέσα τῶν ζώων ἐπὶ τε γῆν καὶ ἐπὶ τὸν ὅλον οὐρανὸν ἐλαφρᾷ φερόμενα ῥύμη. τὸ δὲ ὕδατος πέμπτον ὃν ἡμίθεον μὲν ἀπεικάσειεν ἄν τις ὀρθῶς ἀπεικάζων ἐξ αὐτοῦ γεγονέναι, καὶ τοῦτ' εἶναι τοτὲ μὲν ὀρώμενον, ἄλλοτε δὲ ἀποκρυφθὲν ἄδηλον γιγνόμενον, θαῦμα κατ' ἀμυδρὰν ὄψιν παρεχόμενον. τούτων δὲ τῶν πέντε ὄντως ὄντων ζώων, ὅπη τινὲς ἐνέτυχον ἡμῶν, ἢ καθ' ὕπνον ἐν ὀνειροπολίᾳ προστυχόντες, ἢ κατὰ φήμας τε καὶ μαντείας λεχθέν τισιν ἐν ἀκοαῖς ὑγιαίνουσιν ἢ καὶ κάμνουσιν, ἢ καὶ τελευτῇ βίου προστυχέσι γενομένοις, ἰδίᾳ τε καὶ δημοσίᾳ δόξας παραγενομένας, ὅθεν ἱερὰ πολλὰ πολλῶν γέγονεν, τὰ δὲ γενήσεται, τούτων πάντων νομοθέτης, ὅστις νοῦν κέκτηται καὶ τὸν βραχύτατον, οὐποτε μὴ τολμήσῃ καινοτομῶν, ἐπὶ θεοσέβειαν ἥτις μὴ σαφὲς ἔχει

985d

AT: Now, since there are indeed these five living creatures, howsoever any of us have encountered them, coming across them in dreams whilst asleep, in prophetic statements and utterances heard in health or in disease, or meeting with them at the end of our lives, beliefs develop in individuals or in communities from which various sacred traditions of many peoples have arisen and will arise. And no lawgiver

possessed of reason would ever dare to engage in innovation in any of these, and turn his own city over to some service of God that is insecure. Vile indeed are those who dare not speak of them and reveal that there are these other gods, bereft of rituals, receiving not the honours that are due to them. Wouldn't it be agreed then by the man himself, or anyone who understood the situation, that he might rightly be referred to as a bad man?

τι τρέψαι πόλιν ἑαυτοῦ· καὶ μὴν οὐδ' ὢν ὁ πάτριος νόμος εἴρηκεν περὶ θυσιῶν ἀποκωλύσει, μηδὲν τὸ παράπαν εἰδώς, ὥσπερ οὐδ' ὄν δυνατὸν εἰδέναι τῇ θνητῇ φύσει τῶν τοιούτων πέρι. τοὺς δὲ ὄντως ἡμῖν φανεροὺς ὄντας θεοὺς ἄρ' οὐχ αὐτὸς λόγος ἔχει κακίστους εἶναι τοὺς μὴ τολμῶντας λέγειν ἡμῖν καὶ φανεροὺς ποιεῖν ἀνοργιάστους τε ὄντας ἑτέρους θεοὺς καὶ τιμὰς μὴ δεχομένους τὰς προσηκούσας αὐτοῖς; νῦν δὲ δὴ συμβαίνει γιγνόμενον ἅμα τὸ τοιοῦτον· ΑΘ. οἷον γὰρ εἴ ποτέ τις ἡμῶν ἥλιον ἢ σελήνην ἑωρακὼς ἦν γιγνομένους ἐφορῶντάς τε ἡμᾶς πάντας, καὶ μὴ ἔφραζεν ἀδύνατος ὢν πη φράζειν, τιμῆς τε ἀμοίρους ὄντας ἅμα καὶ μὴ προθυμοῖτο τό γε αὐτοῦ μέρος, εἰς ἔντιμον χώραν καταφανεῖς ἄγων αὐτούς, ἑορτάς τε αὐτοῖς γίγνεσθαι ποιεῖν καὶ θυσίας, ἀπολαμβάνομενόν τε χρόνον ἐκάστοις μειζόνων καὶ ἐλαττόνων πολλάκις

986a

CL: Of course, stranger, the worst of men.

986a

AT: Well then, dear Clinias, mark my words, this is clearly what I am engaged in now.

986a

CL: How so?

986a

AT: Note that there are, in the entire heaven, eight powers that are kindred to one another. These I have observed, and this is no great achievement; in fact, it is easy for anyone. Three of these belong, in one case, to the sun, in another to the moon, and to the stars we

mentioned a little earlier. There are five others. But let no one of us ever believe, idly, that some of these are gods while others are not. Instead, we should all declare and proclaim that these are all kindred and share kindred destinies. Happy is the man who, in the first place, wonders at all this and then develops a passion for understanding as much about this as our mortal nature will allow, deeming this to be the best and most fortunate way to spend his life, and attain after death the regions where excellence abides. Then, having been initiated into truth and reality, being one himself and possessed of one understanding, he will thereafter have a perfect vision of all that is most beautiful, as far as sight allows.

ἐνιαυτῶν ὥρας διανέμειν, ἄρ' οὐκ ἂν κακὸς ἑαυτῷ τε καὶ ἄλλῳ τῷ γινώσκοντι λεγόμενος ἐν δίκῃ συνεδόκει λέγεσθαι ποτ' ἄν; ΚΛ. πῶς γὰρ οὐκ, ὦ ξένε; κάκιστος μὲν οὖν. ΑΘ. τοῦτο τοίνυν, ὦ Κλεινία φίλε, περὶ ἐμὲ νῦν γιγνόμενον ἴσθι φανερώς. ΚΛ. πῶς λέγεις; ΑΘ. ἴστε ὅκτῳ δυνάμεις τῶν περὶ ὅλον οὐρανὸν γεγонуίας ἀδελφὰς ἀλλήλων, ὧν καθεώρακα ἐγώ—καὶ οὐδὲν μέγα διαπέπραγμαί· ῥάδιον γὰρ καὶ ἐτέρῳ —τούτων δ' εἰσὶ τρεῖς αὐται, μία μὲν ἡλίου, μία δὲ σελήνης, μία δὲ τῶν πλανητῶν ἄστρων ὧν ἐμνήσθημεν ὀλίγον ἔμπροσθεν, πέντε δὲ ἕτεραι. ταύτας δὴ πάσας καὶ τούτους τοὺς ἐν ταύταισιν εἴτε αὐτοὺς ἰόντας εἴτε φερομένους ἐν ὀχήμασι πορεύεσθαι ταύτῃ, μηδεὶς ἄλλως ποτὲ νομίσει πάντων ἡμῶν ὡς οἱ μὲν θεοὶ εἰσιν αὐτῶν, οἱ δ' οὐ, μηδ' ὡς οἱ μὲν γνήσιοι, οἱ δὲ τοιοῦτοί τινες οἴους οὐδὲ θέμις εἰπεῖν ἡμῶν οὐδενί, πάντες δὲ δὴ πάντας λέγωμέν τε καὶ φῶμεν ἀδελφούς τ' εἶναι καὶ ἐν ἀδελφαῖς μοίραις, καὶ τιμὰς ἀποδιδῶμεν μὴ τῷ μὲν ἐνιαυτόν, τῷ δὲ μῆνα, τοῖς δὲ μῆτε τινὰ μοῖραν τάττωμεν μῆτε τινὰ χρόνον ἐν ᾧ διεξέρχεται τὸν αὐτοῦ πόλον, συναποτελῶν κόσμον ὃν ἔταξεν λόγος ὁ πάντων θειότατος ὁρατόν· ὃν ὁ μὲν εὐδαίμων πρῶτον μὲν ἐθαύμασεν, ἔπειτα δὲ ἔρωτα ἔσχεν τοῦ καταμαθεῖν ὅποσα θνητῇ φύσει δυνατά, ἡγούμενος ἄρισθ' οὕτως εὐτυχέστατά τε διάξειν τὸν βίον τελευτήσας τε εἰς τόπους ἥξειν προσήκοντας ἀρετῇ, καὶ μεμνημένος ἀληθῶς τε καὶ ὄντως, μεταλαβὼν φρονήσεως εἷς ὧν μιᾶς, τὸν ἐπίλοιπον χρόνον

θεωρὸς τῶν καλλίστων γενόμενος, ὅσα κατ' ὄψιν, διατελεῖ. νῦν δὲ τὸ μετὰ τοῦθ' ἡμῖν λοιπὸν λέγειν ὅσοι τ' εἰσίν, καὶ τίνες· οὐ γὰρ

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AT: What remains for us is to say what and how many of these beings there are, for we should never prove false. I affirm then, with certainty, this much at least: there are eight orbits, three of which have been described already while five still remain. The fourth motion or circuit, together with the fifth, travels at more or less the same speed as the sun, and, in general, neither slower nor faster. Let us say that these are the orbits of the sun, the dawn-bearer, and a third whose name we cannot utter because it is unknown, the reason being that the person who first observed these was a non-Greek.

μήποτε φανῶμεν ψευδεῖς. βεβαίως δὲ διισχυρίζομαι τό γε τοσοῦτον. λέγω γὰρ πάλιν ὀκτώ μὲν εἶναι, τῶν δὲ ὀκτώ τρεῖς μὲν εἰρησθαι, πέντε δ' ἔτι λοιπὰς. ἡ τετάρτη δὲ φορὰ καὶ διέξοδος ἅμα καὶ πέμπτη τάχει μὲν ἡλίῳ σχεδὸν ἴση, καὶ οὔτε βραδυτέρα οὔτε θάττων τό γ' ἐπίπαν. δεῖ τούτων τριῶν ὄντων τὸν νοῦν ἱκανὸν ἔχοντα ἡγεῖσθαι. λέγωμεν δὲ ταύτας ἡλίου τ' εἶναι καὶ ἑωσφόρου, καὶ τρίτου—ὥς μὲν ὀνόματι φράζειν οὐκ ἔστιν διὰ τὸ μὴ γιγνώσκεισθαι, τούτου δ' αἴτιος ὁ πρῶτος ταῦτα κατιδὼν βάρβαρος ὢν ΑΘ. παλαιὸς γὰρ δὴ

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AT: An ancient circumstance encouraged the first observers. Because Egypt and Syria are blessed with an excellent summer season, they had a more or less continuous view of all the stars, since clouds and rains are consistently absent from that part of the world. And so their observations, well tested over a vast, nay limitless, period of time, have spread abroad and arrived here. Therefore, we must be courageous enough to pass laws for these, since it obviously makes no sense that some divinities are honoured while others are not. For the dawn-bearer, which is the same as the evening star, is, by common account, the star of Aphrodite, and this is a most appropriate name for a Syrian convention setter to assign. That which runs its course more or less along with this, and with the sun too, is the star of Hermes. We should

also mention three further orbits of bodies proceeding to the right along with the moon and the sun. And we should also mention one, the eighth, which may especially be referred to as the Cosmos, proceeding in the opposite direction to all those, leading the others.

τρόπος ἔθρεψεν τοὺς πρώτους ταῦτα ἐννοήσαντας διὰ τὸ κάλλος τῆς θερινῆς ὥρας, ἣν Αἴγυπτός τε Συρία θ' ἱκανῶς κέκτῃται, φανεροὺς μὲν ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν ἀστέρας ἀεὶ σύμπαντας καθορῶντας, ἅτε νεφῶν καὶ ὑδάτων ἀπόπροσθεν ἀεὶ τοῦ κόσμου κεκτημένων, ὅθεν καὶ πανταχόσε καὶ δεῦρ' ἐξήκει, βεβασανισμένα χρόνῳ μυριετῇ τε καὶ ἀπείρῳ. διὸ θαρροῦντα χρὴ ταῦτα εἰς νόμους θέσθαι—τὸ γὰρ μὴ τίμια τὰ θεῖα εἶναι, τὰ δὲ τίμια, σαφῶς οὐκ ἐμφρόνων—ὅτι δὲ οὐκ ὀνόματα ἔσχηκεν, τήν γε αἰτίαν χρὴ λέγεσθαι ταύτην. ἀλλὰ γὰρ ἐπωνυμίαν εἰλήφασιν θεῶν· ὁ μὲν γὰρ ἑωσφόρος ἔσπερος τε ὦν αὐτὸς ἀφροδίτης εἶναι σχεδὸν ἔχει λόγον καὶ μάλα Συρίῳ νομοθέτῃ πρέπον, ὁ δ' ὁμόδρομος ἡλίῳ τε ἅμα καὶ τούτῳ σχεδὸν Ἑρμοῦ. τρεῖς δ' ἔτι φορὰς λέγωμεν ἐπὶ δεξιὰ πορευομένων μετὰ σελήνης τε καὶ ἡλίου. ἓνα δὲ τὸν ὄγδοον χρὴ λέγειν, ὃν μάλιστά τις ἂν κόσμον προσαγορεύοι, ὃς ἐναντίος ἐκείνοις σύμπασιν πορεύεται, οὐκ ἄγων τοὺς ἄλλους, ὥς γε ἀνθρώποις φαίνοιτ' ἂν ὀλίγα τούτων εἰδόσιν. ὅσα δὲ ἱκανῶς ἴσμεν, ἀνάγκη λέγειν καὶ λέγομεν· ἡ γὰρ ὄντως οὕσα σοφία ταύτῃ πῃ φαίνεται τῷ καὶ σμικρὰ συννοίας ὀρθῆς θείας τε μετειληφότε. λοιποὶ δὲ τρεῖς ἀστέρες, ὧν εἷς μὲν βραδυτῇ διαφέρων αὐτῶν ἐστὶ, Κρόνου δ' αὐτόν τινες ἐπωνυμίαν φθέγγονται· τὸν δὲ μετὰ τοῦτον βραδυτῇ λέγειν χρὴ Διός, Ἄρεως δὲ ὁ μετὰ τοῦτον, πάντων δὲ οὗτος ἐρυθρώτατον ἔχει χρῶμα. χαλεπὸν δὲ οὐδὲν τούτων κατανοῆσαί

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AT: The actual truth seems somehow to lie in this direction. Three stars remain, one of which is much slower than the others, and some people take this to be the star of Cronus; the next slowest should be called the star of Zeus, and after this comes the star of Ares, which has the reddest colour of all. None of these phenomena are difficult to apprehend once someone has described them, but it is necessary for someone who has understood the matter to take the lead.

τινα φράζοντός τινος, ἀλλὰ μαθόντα, ὡς λέγομεν, ἡγεῖσθαι δεῖ. τόδε γε μὴν διανοηθῆναι χρή πάντ' ἄνδρα Ἑλλήνα, ὡς τόπον ἔχομεν τὸν τῶν Ἑλλήνων πρὸς ἀρετὴν ἐν τοῖς σχεδὸν ἄριστον· τὸ δ' ἐπαινετὸν αὐτοῦ χρή λέγειν ὅτι μέσος ἂν εἴη χειμῶνων τε καὶ τῆς θερινῆς φύσεως, ἡ δ' ὑστεροῦσα ἡμῖν εἰς τὸ θερινὸν φύσις τοῦ περὶ τὸν ἐκεῖ τόπον, ὅπερ εἵπομεν, ὕστερον αὐτοῖς παραδέδωκεν τὸ τούτων τῶν θεῶν τοῦ κόσμου κατανόημα. λάβωμεν δὲ ὡς ὅτιπερ ἂν Ἑλληνες βαρβάρων

987e

AT: Now, there is something that every Greek should understand: the region we Greeks inhabit is perhaps the best of all for the acquisition of human excellence. And in praise of this, it should be explained that our climate is a mean between the extremes of winter and summer. Although such matters as these are difficult to investigate with certainty, there is, nevertheless, a great and noble expectation that we Greeks will exercise a better and, indeed, a more just concern for all these gods than the tradition and worship that has come from the non-Greeks. For we will make use of instruction and prophecy that comes from Delphi, and the entire system of worship ordained by our laws. And let none of us Greeks ever harbour the fear that mere mortals must refrain from engagement with matters divine. We should hold the very opposite view: that the divine is never devoid of intelligence, nor somehow ignorant of our human nature.

παραλάβωσι, κάλλιον τοῦτο εἰς τέλος ἀπεργάζονται ΑΘ. καὶ δὴ καὶ περὶ τὰ νῦν λεγόμενα ταῦτ' ὁ δεῖ διανοηθῆναι τοῦτο, ὡς χαλεπὸν μὲν πάντα τὰ τοιαῦτα ἀναμφισβητήτως ἐξευρίσκειν, πολλὴ δ' ἐλπίς ἅμα καὶ καλὴ κάλλιον καὶ δικαιότερον ὄντως τῆς ἐκ τῶν βαρβάρων ἐλθούσης φήμης τε ἅμα καὶ θεραπείας πάντων τούτων τῶν θεῶν ἐπιμελήσεσθαι τοὺς Ἑλλήνας, παιδείαις τε καὶ ἐκ Δελφῶν μαντείαις χρωμένους καὶ πάσῃ τῇ κατὰ νόμους θεραπείᾳ. τόδε δὲ μηδεὶς ποτε φοβηθῇ τῶν Ἑλλήνων, ὡς οὐ χρή περὶ τὰ θεῖα ποτε πραγματεύεσθαι θνητοὺς ὄντας, πᾶν δὲ τούτῳ διανοηθῆναι τούναντίον, ὡς οὔτε ἄφρον ἐστὶν ποτε τὸ θεῖον οὔτε ἄγνοεῖ πού τὴν ἀνθρωπίνην φύσιν, ἀλλ' οἶδεν ὅτι διδάσκοντος αὐτοῦ συνακολουθήσει καὶ μαθήσεται τὰ διδασκόμενα. ὅτι δὲ διδάσκει τοῦτο

αὐτὸ ἡμᾶς, μανθάνομεν δὲ ἡμεῖς ἀριθμόν τε καὶ ἀριθμεῖν, οἶδεν δῆπου. πάντων γὰρ ἀφρονέστατον ἂν εἴη τοῦτο ἀγνοοῦν· τὸ λεγόμενον γὰρ ἂν ὄντως αὐτὸ αὐτὸ ἀγνοοῖ, χαλεπαῖνον τῷ δυναμένῳ μανθάνειν, ἀλλ' οὐ συγχαῖρον ἄνευ φθόνου διὰ θεὸν ἀγαθῷ γενομένῳ. λόγον δὴ καὶ πολὺν καὶ

988c

AT: Now, there is an account, widespread and plausible, that there was a time when humans had their initial conceptions of the gods and how they came into being, and the sort of beings they were and how they engaged in various activities. But the accounts were neither acceptable to nor to the liking of the sound-minded. Nor could they accept the subsequent accounts in which priority was attributed to fire and water and other bodies, and lower status given to the wondrous soul. But now, since we are saying that soul, once it has actually come to be present in the body, naturally moves and circulates both itself and the body, it is no wonder that soul is the cause of all circulation and motion, that the circulation and motion towards the good belongs to the best soul, while the opposite holds for the opposite kind of soul, and anything that is good must prevail, now and ever, over its opposite.

καλὸν ἔχει, τότε μέν, ὅτε περὶ θεῶν ἦν ἀνθρώποις διανοήματα πρῶτα, ὥς τε ἐγένοντο οἰοί τε ἐγίγνοντο καὶ ὁ μὲν καὶ οἷας μετεχειρίζοντο πράξεις, μὴ κατὰ νοῦν τοῖς σώφροσιν λέγεσθαι μηδὲ φίλως, μηδ' ὥς οἱ δεῦτεροι, ἐν οἷς πρεσβύτερα μὲν τὰ πυρὸς ἐλέγετο καὶ ὕδατος καὶ τῶν ἄλλων σωμάτων, ὕστερα δὲ τὰ τῆς θαυμαστῆς ψυχῆς, καὶ φορὰ κρείττων καὶ τιμιωτέρα, ἣν σῶμα εἴληχεν φέρειν αὐτό τε ἑαυτὸ θερμότητι καὶ ψύξεσιν καὶ πᾶσιν τοῖς τοιούτοις, ἀλλ' οὐ ψυχὴ σῶμά τε καὶ ἑαυτήν· νῦν δ' ὅτε λέγομεν ψυχὴν μὲν, ἅνπερ ἐν σώματι γένηται, θαῦμα οὐδὲν κινεῖν τε καὶ περιφέρειν τοῦτο καὶ ἑαυτήν, οὐδ' ἡμῖν ἀπιστεῖ ψυχὴ κατὰ λόγον οὐδένα ὥς βάρος οὐδὲν περιφέρειν δυναμένη. διὸ καὶ νῦν ἡμῶν ἀξιούντων, ψυχῆς οὔσης αἰτίας τοῦ ὅλου, καὶ πάντων μὲν τῶν ἀγαθῶν ὄντων τοιούτων, τῶν δὲ αὖ φλαύρων τοιούτων ἄλλων, τῆς μὲν φορᾶς πάσης καὶ κινήσεως ψυχὴν αἰτίαν

εἶναι θαῦμα οὐδέν, τὴν δ' ἐπὶ τὰγαθὸν φορὰν καὶ κίνησιν τῆς ἀρίστης ψυχῆς εἶναι, τὴν δ' ἐπὶ τοῦναντίον ἐναντίαν, νενικηκέναι δεῖ καὶ νικᾶν τὰ ἀγαθὰ τὰ μὴ τοιαῦτα. ΑΘ. ταῦτα ἡμῖν εἴρηται πάντα κατὰ τὴν τῶν ἀνοσίων τιμωρὸν δὲ δίκην· περὶ δὲ δὴ τὸ δοκιμαζόμενον οὐχ οἷόν τε ἡμῖν ἀπιστεῖν ὥς οὐ δεῖ τὸν γε ἀγαθὸν σοφὸν ἡμᾶς ἡγεῖσθαι,

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AT: We have said all this according to justice, the avenger of those who are unholy. But, regarding the matter under scrutiny, we cannot but believe that we should regard the good as wise. As for the wisdom we have sought for so long, we should see whether we can discern this in some education or skill whose lack of recognition among the just would render us ignorant for being like this.

τὴν δὲ σοφίαν ταύτην, ἣν ζητοῦμεν πάλοι, ἴδωμεν ἂν ποτ' ἄρα ἐπινοήσωμεν ἢ κατὰ παιδείαν ἢ κατὰ τέχνην, ἥντινα τοῦ γινώσκειν ἐνδεεῖς ὄντες τῶν δικαίων, ἀγνώμονες ἂν εἴμεν ὄντες τοιοῦτοι. δοκοῦμεν δὴ μοι, καὶ λεκτέον· ἄνω γὰρ καὶ κάτω ζητῶν ἧ μοι καταφανῆς γέγονεν, πειράσομαι δὴλην ὑμῖν αὐτὴν ἀποτελεῖν. τὸ δὴ μέγιστον ἀρετῆς οὐ καλῶς πραττόμενον ἡμῖν γέγονεν αἴτιον, ὥς ἄρτι σημαίνειν ἐκ τῶν

989b

AT: Indeed, I am strongly of the view, as indicated by what has just been said, that our failures in practising the most important part of excellence is responsible for our predicament. And it must be said that for our mortal race there is no part of excellence more important than reverence, and we should never be persuaded to the contrary. But through the utmost ignorance, this reverence has not arisen in the very best natures. The very best natures are those that, although they come into existence only with extreme difficulty, nevertheless confer enormous benefit when they do arise. For the soul that quietly accepts its due measure of lethargy and its opposite would be good-natured, admire courage, and be easily persuaded towards sound-mindedness. And, most importantly in such natures, soul is able to learn, has a good

memory and is able to delight in these qualities, and thus develop a love of learning.

εἰρημένων μοι σφόδρα δοκεῖ. μεῖζον μὲν γὰρ ἀρετῆς μηδεὶς ἡμᾶς ποτε πείσῃ τῆς εὐσεβείας εἶναι τῷ θνητῷ γενεῖν τοῦτο δ' ὅτι δι' ἀμαθίαν τὴν μεγίστην ἐν ταῖς ἀρίστοις φύσεσιν οὐ γέγονεν, λεκτέον. ἄρισται δ' εἰσὶν αἱ χαλεπώτατα μὲν ἂν γενόμεναι, μέγιστον δὲ ὄφελος, ἂν γίγνωνται· τά τε γὰρ τῆς βραδείας τε καὶ τῆς ἐναντίας φύσεως μετρίως ἀποδεχομένη ψυχὴ καὶ πρῶως, εὐκόλος ἂν εἴη, τὴν τε ἀνδρείαν ἀγαμένη, καὶ πρὸς τὸ σωφρονεῖν εὐπειθής, καὶ τό γε μέγιστον, ἐν ταύταις ταῖς φύσεσιν δυναμένη μανθάνειν καὶ μνήμων οὔσα, εὖ μάλα χαίρειν τούτοις αὐτοῖς δύναιτ' ἂν φιλομαθῆς ὥστ' εἶναι. ταῦτα γὰρ οὔτε ῥάδια φύεσθαι, γενόμενά τε, καὶ τροφῆς καὶ παιδείας τυχόντα ἥς δεῖ, τοὺς πλείστους αὐτῶν καὶ χεῖρους κατέχειν ὀρθότατα δύναιτ' ἂν τῷ φρονεῖν καὶ πράττειν καὶ λέγειν περὶ θεοὺς ἕκαστα ὡς δεῖ τε καὶ ὅτε δεῖ, περὶ θυσίας τε καὶ καθαρμῶν τῶν περὶ θεοὺς τε καὶ ἀνθρώπων, οὐ σχήμασι τεχνάζοντας, ἀλλὰ ἀληθείᾳ τιμῶντας

989d

AT: For although these qualities are not easy to develop, once they have arisen and have encountered the nurture and education they need, they would be able to constrain the majority of people, the baser sort, in the right way, to think, act and speak about the gods as they should and when they should in relation to sacrifices and purifications belonging to the gods and to humans, not as a mere outward show, but truly valuing excellence, which is indeed of the utmost importance for everyone in every city. According to us, then, this part is, by nature, the most exalted and well capable of learning all that is noblest and best, provided there is a teacher. But there would be no teaching unless God were to take the lead.

ἀρετὴν, ὃ δὴ καὶ μέγιστόν ἐστι συμπάντων πάσῃ τῇ πόλει. τοῦτο δὴ οὖν τὸ μέρος εἶναί φαμεν φύσει κυριώτατον καὶ δυνατόν ὡς οἶόν τε κάλλιστα καὶ ἄριστα μαθεῖν, εἰ διδάσκοι τις. ἀλλ' οὐδ' ἂν διδάξειεν, εἰ μὴ θεὸς ὑφηγοῖτο· εἰ τ' οὖν διδάσκοι, κατὰ τρόπον δὲ μὴ δρῶ τὸ

τοιούτον, κρείττον μὴ μανθάνειν. ὅμως δ' ἐκ τῶν νῦν λεγομένων ἀνάγκη μαθεῖν ταῦτα καὶ ἐμὲ λέγειν τὴν τοιαύτην τε καὶ ἀρίστην φύσιν.

989e

AT: Let us attempt, then, to give an account explaining what these things are, their characteristics, and how they should be learned, to the best of my ability as the speaker and your abilities as listeners. So, in what way may someone learn to serve God? Now, although it may sound strange on first hearing, we should at least state its name, a name which someone with no experience of the subject would never guess. The subject is astronomy, but people are unaware that the true astronomer must necessarily be utterly wise. He should not engage in astronomy, as did Hesiod and so many others like him, by observing risings and settings, rather than observing seven orbits of the eight as they each proceed in a way that would be beyond the capacity of most natures to discern easily. An exceptional nature would be required.

πειρώμεθα δὴ τῷ τε λόγῳ διεξελθεῖν ἃ τ' ἐστὶν καὶ οἷα καὶ ὥς δεῖ μανθάνειν, κατὰ δύναμιν τὴν τ' ἐμὴν τοῦ λέγοντος καὶ τὴν τῶν δυναμένων εἰσακοῦσαι, θεοσεβείας ᾧτινι τρόπῳ τις τίνα μαθήσεται. ΑΘ. σχεδὸν μὲν οὖν ἐστὶν ἄτοπον ἀκούσαντι, τὸ δ' ὄνομα αὐτοῦ λέγομεν ἡμεῖς γε, ὃ τις οὐκ ἂν ποτε δόξειεν δι' ἀπειρίαν τοῦ πράγματος—ἀστρονομίαν—ἀγνοεῖ τε ὅτι σοφώτατον ἀνάγκη τὸν ἀληθῶς ἀστρονόμον εἶναι, μὴ τὸν καθ' Ἡσίοδον ἀστρονομοῦντα καὶ πάντας τοὺς τοιούτους, οἷον δυσμὰς τε καὶ ἀνατολὰς ἐπεσκεμμένον, ἀλλὰ τὸν τῶν ὀκτὼ περιόδων τὰς ἐπτὰ περιόδους, διεξιούσης τὸν αὐτῶν κύκλον

990b

AT: The moon traverses its orbit fastest, bringing the month and the full moon first. Next, we should observe the sun throughout its entire cycle, and those bodies that run their course along with it as it brings the solstices. Now, let's just say that the other orbits of these bodies as described previously are not easy to understand, and to produce natures that are up to the task it is necessary to work hard and consistently at basic education and training in childhood and youth. Certain studies would therefore be required. First and foremost is that

of numbers themselves, devoid of anything physical, concerned rather with the overall generation of odd and even, and the influence this has upon the nature of things that are.

ἐκάστης οὕτως ὥς οὐκ ἂν ῥαδίως ποτὲ πᾶσα φύσις ἱκανὴ γένοιτο θεωρῆσαι, μὴ θαυμαστῆς μετέχουσα φύσεως. ὃ νῦν εἰρήκαμεν ἐροῦμέν τε, ὥς φαμεν, ὅπῃ δεῖ τε καὶ ὅπως χρεὼν μανθάνειν· πρῶτον δ' ἡμῖν τόδε λεγέσθω. σελήνη μὲν περίοδον τὴν αὐτῆς τάχιστα διέξεισιν, ἄγουσα μῆνα καὶ πανσέληνον πρώτην· δεύτερον δὲ κατανοεῖν δεῖ τὸν ἥλιον, τροπὰς ἄγοντα διὰ πάσης τῆς αὐτοῦ περιόδου, καὶ τούτῳ τοὺς συνδρόμους. ἵνα δὲ μὴ πολλάκις ταῦτ' ἀπὸ τῶν αὐτῶν διαλεγώμεθα, τὰς ἄλλας ὅσας ἐν τῷ πρόσθεν διεξήλθομεν ὁδοὺς τούτων οὐ ῥάδιον συνοεῖν, ἐπὶ δὲ ταῦτα παρασκευάζοντας φύσεις οἷας δυνατόν εἶναι, χρεὼν πολλὰ προδιδάσκοντα καὶ ἐθίζοντα αἰεὶ διαπρονήσασθαι παῖδα ὄντα καὶ νεανίσκον. διὸ μαθημάτων δέον ἂν εἶη τὸ δὲ μέγιστόν τε καὶ πρῶτον καὶ ἀριθμῶν αὐτῶν ἄλλ' οὐ σώματα ἐχόντων, ἀλλὰ ὅλης τῆς τοῦ περιττοῦ τε καὶ ἀρτίου γενέσεώς τε καὶ δυνάμεως, ὅσην παρέχεται πρὸς τὴν τῶν ὄντων φύσιν.

990d

AT: Having learned this, what comes next goes by the very strange name of geometry, which, by reference to part of plane surfaces, produces a likeness of numbers that are not by nature like one another. Now, it should be evident to anyone who could understand this marvel that it is no mere human contrivance, but divine in origin. After this are numbers that multiply threefold, and are like unto the three-dimensional. Then again, those that are unlike are made like by a different skill, which those who are acquainted with it call stereometry. This is godly, and a wonder to those who look closely and appreciate that nature in its entirety, in the case of each ratio, is continually turning power, and the opposite to this, about the double. In the means between these themselves, in both senses, the benefit of consonance and symmetry is bestowed upon humanity in furtherance of the play of rhythm and harmony, a gift from the blessed chorus of the Muses.

ταῦτα δὲ μαθόντι τούτοις ἐφεξῆς ἐστὶν ὃ καλοῦσι μὲν σφόδρα γελοῖον ὄνομα γεωμετρίαν, τῶν οὐκ ὄντων δὲ ὁμοίων ἀλλήλοις φύσει ἀριθμῶν ὁμοιώσις πρὸς τὴν τῶν ἐπιπέδων μοῖραν γεγонуῖα ἐστὶν διαφανής· ὃ δὴ θαῦμα οὐκ ἀνθρώπινον ἀλλὰ γεγονὸς θεῖον φανερόν ἂν γίγνοιτο τῷ δυναμένῳ συννοεῖν. μετὰ δὲ ταύτην τοὺς τρεῖς ἠϋξημένους καὶ τῇ στερεᾷ φύσει ὁμοίους· τοὺς δὲ ἀνομοίους αὖ γεγονότας ἑτέρα τέχνη ὁμοιοῖ, ταύτη ἦν δὴ στερεομετρίαν ἐκάλεσαν οἱ προστυχεῖς αὐτῇ γεγονότες· ὃ δὲ θεῖόν τ' ἐστὶν καὶ θαυμαστόν τοις ἐγκαθορῶσί τε καὶ διανοουμένοις ὡς περὶ τὸ διπλάσιον αἰεὶ στρεφομένης τῆς δυνάμεως καὶ τῆς ἐξ ἐναντίας ταύτη καθ' ἐκάστην ἀναλογίαν εἶδος καὶ γένος ἀποτυποῦται

991a

AT: So much, then, for all these matters, let them be as we have described them. But to bring them to a conclusion, we should proceed to a divine creation that is at once most beautiful to behold, and, indeed, the most divine production of any that God has allowed us humans to have sight of. But no one can ever claim to have understood this easily without a clear vision of everything we are now explaining. We must also grasp the precision of the timing, and how precisely all the phenomena of the heaven are completed, so that anyone who has come to believe in the truth of our argument that soul is older than body, and more divine too, would come to the view that it is right and reasonable to declare that “everything is full of gods”, and that we will never be neglected by our superiors through their forgetfulness or inattention.

πᾶσα ἡ φύσις. ΑΘ. ἡ μὲν δὴ πρώτη τοῦ διπλασίου κατ' ἀριθμὸν ἐν πρὸς δύο κατὰ λόγον φερομένη, διπλάσιον δὲ ἡ κατὰ δύναμιν οὕσα ἡ δ' εἰς τὸ στερεόν τε καὶ ἀπτόν πάλιν αὖ διπλάσιον, ἀφ' ἐνὸς εἰς ὅκτῳ διαπορευθεῖσα· ἡ δὲ διπλασίου μὲν εἰς μέσον, ἴσως δὲ τοῦ ἐλάττονος πλέον ἔλαττόν τε τοῦ μείζονος, τὸ δ' ἕτερον τῷ αὐτῷ μέρει τῶν ἄκρων αὐτῶν ὑπερέχον τε καὶ ὑπερεχόμενον—ἐν μέσῳ δὲ τοῦ ἕξ πρὸς τὰ δώδεκα συνέβη τό τε ἡμιόλιον καὶ ἐπίτριτον—τούτων αὐτῶν ἐν τῷ μέσῳ ἐπ' ἀμφοτέρα στρεφομένη τοῖς ἀνθρώποις σύμφωνον χρεῖαν καὶ

σύμμετρον ἀπενείματο παιδιᾶς ῥυθμοῦ τε καὶ ἀρμονίας χάριν, εὐδαίμονι χορεΐα Μουσῶν δεδομένη. ταῦτα μὲν οὖν δὴ ταύτῃ γιγνέσθω τε καὶ ἔχέτω σύμπαντα· τὸ δ' ἐπὶ τούτοις τέλος, εἰς θεῖαν γένεσιν ἅμα καὶ τὴν τῶν ὁρατῶν καλλίστην τε καὶ θειοτάτην φύσιν ἰτέον, ὅσῃν ἀνθρώποις θεὸς ἔδωκεν κατιδεῖν, ἣν οὐποτε ἄνευ τῶν νῦν

991c

AT: In relation to all matters of this sort, it is necessary to bear in mind that if someone grasps each of these aright, a great benefit accrues to whoever apprehends systematically. It is necessary to explain what we mean by ‘systematically’. Every geometric construction, every numerical system and harmonic⁶ structure, and the unified agreement of all the circuits of the stars, should be revealed to the person who learns systematically. And revealed they shall be if, as we say, a person learns aright by looking towards one. For a single bond naturally uniting all these will be revealed to those who think about things in this way. For without these studies, no happy person will make an appearance in our cities. This is the system, this is the upbringing, these are the subjects, and whether it be difficult or easy, this is the course along which we must proceed.

διειρημένων μὴ κατιδὼν ἐπεύξηται τις ῥαστώνῃ παραλαβεῖν. πρὸς τούτοις δὲ τὸ καθ' ἓν τῷ κατ' εἶδη προσακτέον ἐν ἐκάσταις ταῖς συνουσίαις, ἐρωτῶντά τε καὶ ἐλέγχοντα τὰ μὴ καλῶς ῥηθέντα· πάντως γὰρ καλλίστη καὶ πρώτη βάσανος ἀνθρώποις ὀρθῶς γίγνεται, ὅσαι δὲ οὐκ οὔσαι προσποιοῦνται, ματαιότατος πόνος ἀπάντων. ἔτι δὲ τὴν ἀκρίβειαν τοῦ χρόνου ἡμῖν ληπτέον, ὥς ἀκριβῶς ἀποτελεῖ πάντα τὰ κατ' οὐρανὸν γιγνόμενα, ἵν' ὁ πιστεύσας ὥς ὁ λόγος ἀληθῆς γέγονεν ὅτι πρεσβύτερόν τ' ἐστὶν ἅμα καὶ θειότερον ψυχῇ σώματος, ἡγήσασθ' ἂν παγκάλως τε καὶ ἱκανῶς εἰρῆσθαι τὸ θεῶν εἶναι πάντα πλέα καὶ μηδέποτε λήθῃ μηδὲ ἀμελεία τῶν κρειττόνων ἡμᾶς παρωλιγωρῆσθαι. νοητέον δ' ἐστὶν περὶ πάντα τὰ τοιαῦτα τόδε, ὥς, ἐὰν μὲν τις ἕκαστα τούτων ὀρθῶς λαμβάνῃ, μέγ' ὄφελος γίγνεται τῷ παραλαμβάνοντι κατὰ τρόπον, εἰ δὲ μή, θεὸν ἄμεινον αἰεὶ καλεῖν· ὁ δὲ τρόπος ὅδε — ἀνάγκη γὰρ τό γε τοσοῦτον φράζειν—πᾶν διάγραμμα ἀριθμοῦ τε

σύστημα καὶ ἀρμονίας σύστασιν ἅπασαν τῆς τε τῶν ἄστρον περιφορᾶς τὴν ὁμολογίαν οὖσαν μίαν ἀπάντων ἀναφανῆναι δεῖ τῷ κατὰ τρόπον μανθάνοντι, φανήσεται δέ, ἄν, ὃ λέγομεν, ὀρθῶς τις εἰς ἓν βλέπων μανθάνη— ΑΘ. δεσμὸς

992a

AT: Whoever has grasped all these subjects together is deemed by me as most truly the wisest. Of such a person, I insist, in jest and in all seriousness too, that when his destiny is fulfilled in death – if we may say that he still persists after death – he will no longer partake of a multiplicity of perceptions as he does now. Having a share of one destiny alone, having become one from many, he will be happy and wise, and blessed too, and whether he lives this blessed life on continents or on certain islands, he will forever share in good fortune of this sort.

γὰρ πεφυκὼς πάντων τούτων εἷς ἀναφανήσεται διανοουμένοις —εἰ δ' ἄλλως πως ταῦτα μεταχειριεῖται τις, τύχην δεῖ καλεῖν, ὥσπερ καὶ λέγομεν. οὐ γὰρ ἄνευ γε τούτων μήποτε τις ἐν πόλεσιν εὐδαίμων γένηται φύσις, ἀλλ' οὗτος ὁ τρόπος, αὕτη ἡ τροφή, ταῦτα τὰ μαθήματα· εἴτε χαλεπὰ εἴτε ῥάδια, ταῦτη πορευτέον. ἀμελεῖσαι δὲ οὐ θεμιτόν ἐστιν θεῶν, καταφανοὺς γενομένης τῆς πάντων αὐτῶν κατὰ τρόπον λεγομένης φήμης εὐτυχοῦς. τὸν δὲ σύμπαντα ταῦτα οὕτως εἰληφότα, τοῦτον λέγω τὸν ἀληθέστατα σοφώτατον· ὃν καὶ διςχυρίζομαι παίζων καὶ σπουδάζων ἅμα, ὅτε θανάτῳ τις τῶν τοιούτων τὴν αὐτοῦ μοῖραν ἀναπλήσει, σχεδὸν ἔάνπερ ἔτ' ἀποθανὼν ἦ, μήτε μεθέξειν ἔτι πολλῶν τότε καθάπερ νῦν αἰσθήσεων, μιᾶς τε μοίρας μετείληφότα μόνον καὶ ἐκ πολλῶν ἕνα γεγονότα, εὐδαίμονά τε ἔσσεσθαι καὶ σοφώτατον ἅμα καὶ μακάριον, εἴτε τις ἐν ἡπείροις εἴτ' ἐν νήσοις μακάριος ὢν

992c

AT: The same argument is presenting itself now, the one we stated at the very outset, and it really is true that, with few exceptions, it is not possible for us humans to be perfectly blessed and happy. For only those who are divine and sound-minded and naturally share in excellence in general, and, furthermore, have grasped everything that

is contained in the blessed subject – and we have explained what this involves – only these people adequately acquire and retain the entirety of that which belongs to the divine. And so, we maintain in private and enact in public, in our laws, that those who work at these studies in the right way should be awarded the highest positions of authority in their advanced later years. The others, speaking reverently towards all the gods and goddesses, are to follow such people, and it is only right that all of us, having properly recognised this wisdom and put it to the test, should call upon the Nocturnal Council to pursue it too.

ζῆ, κάκεῖνον μεθέξειν τῆς τοιαύτης ἀεὶ τύχης, κεῖτε δημοσίᾳ τις ἐπιτηδεύσας ταῦτα εἴτε ἰδίᾳ διαβιῶ, τὰ αὐτὰ καὶ ὡσαύτως αὐτὸν πράξειν παρὰ θεῶν. ὃ δὲ κατ' ἀρχὰς τε ἐλέγομεν, καὶ νῦν αὐτὸς πάρεστι λόγος ἀληθῆς ὄντως, ὡς οὐ δυνατόν ἀνθρώποις τελέως μακαρίους τε καὶ εὐδαίμοσι γενέσθαι πλὴν ὀλίγων, ἔστιν ταῦτα ὀρθῶς εἰρημένα· ὁπόσοι γὰρ θεῖοι καὶ σώφρονες ἅμα τῆς ἄλλης τε μετέχοντες ἀρετῆς φύσει, πρὸς δὲ τούτοις ὅσα μαθήματος ἔχεται μακαρίου πάντα εἰληφότες —ἃ δ' ἔστιν εἰρήκαμεν—τούτοισιν μόνοις τὰ τοῦ δαιμονίου σύμπαντα ἱκανῶς εἴληχέ τε καὶ ἔχει. τοῖς μὲν οὖν ταῦτα οὕτω διαπονήσασιν ἰδίᾳ λέγομεν καὶ δημοσίᾳ κατὰ νόμον τίθεμεν, εἰς πρεσβύτου τέλος ἀφικομένοις τὰς μεγίστας ἀρχὰς παραδίδοσθαι δεῖν, τοὺς δ' ἄλλους τούτοις συνεπομένους εὐφημεῖν πάντας θεοὺς ἅμα καὶ πάσας, καὶ τὸν νυκτερινὸν σύλλογον ἐπὶ ταύτην τὴν σοφίαν ἱκανῶς γνόντας τε καὶ δοκιμάσαντας ἡμᾶς ὀρθότατα πάντας παρακαλεῖν.

Notes

¹ This introduces the notion of ratio.

² This picks up on the argument from Laws x.

³ Laws x.891e ff, 896a ff.

⁴ Stereometry is the measurement of solids.

⁵ These three progressions represent the transition from one dimension to three dimensions. The values of one-dimensionality, which are based on the

ratio of 1:2, are squared to obtain the values of two-dimensionality, and cubed to get the values of the 'solid and tangible' third dimension.

⁶ These ratios are obtained through taking the arithmetic mean, 9, and the harmonic mean, 8, between 6 and 12: $9:6 = 3:2$ and $8:6 = 4:3$; $12:8 = 3:2$ and $12:9 = 4:3$.

⁷ Aristotle in his *De Anima* (I.5.411a8) attributes this phrase to the pre-Socratic philosopher Thales.